

ABSTRACT

Phishing URL detection is a critical cybersecurity task, as deceptive links frequently trick users into compromising sensitive credentials. While machine learning (ML) approaches demonstrate strong baseline accuracy, purely data-driven solutions operate as opaque "black boxes" vulnerable to zero-day URL evasions. Conversely, heuristic rule engines provide fast, deterministic decisions but offer limited adaptability to evolving attack vectors and suffer from elevated false positive rates. To address these limitations, this paper introduces ShieldPhish, a hybrid phishing URL detection framework that dynamically integrates lightweight heuristic rules with an ML pipeline backed by SHAP Explainable AI (XAI). The system extracts a 112-dimensional feature vector spanning structural lexical statistics, security indicators, Shannon entropy, and character-level TF-IDF n-grams to train XGBoost, Random Forest, Calibrated Linear SVM, and a custom NumPy-based Logistic Regression classifier. A bounded fusion strategy dynamically combines ML probabilities with heuristic penalty scores, acting as an unconditional safety override for low-confidence ML predictions to mitigate evasion risks. Evaluated on a merged corpus of 957,334 URLs using 5-fold stratified cross-validation, the Random Forest model achieves 99.40% accuracy, while XGBoost achieves 93.16% accuracy with an ROC AUC of 0.9809. Optimized tree ensembles paired with TreeSHAP feature attributions deliver transparent decision rationales for security analysts at sub-millisecond inference latency. Ultimately, ShieldPhish bridges statistical machine learning with deterministic heuristic verification to enable robust, real-time threat detection.

KEYWORDS: *Phishing URL Detection, Hybrid Machine Learning, Explainable AI (XAI), SHAP, XGBoost, Random Forest, Heuristic Rule Engine, Cybersecurity.*

LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

API	Application Programming Interface
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ASGI	Asynchronous Server Gateway Interface
AUC	Area Under Curve
BERT	Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers
CORS	Cross-Origin Resource Sharing
CPU	Central Processing Unit
CRISP-DM	Cross-Industry Standard Process for Data Mining
DFD	Data Flow Diagram
DGA	Domain Generation Algorithm
DNS	Domain Name System
FFT	Fast Fourier Transform
FN	False Negative
FP	False Positive
HTTP	Hypertext Transfer Protocol
HTTPS	Hypertext Transfer Protocol Secure
JSON	JavaScript Object Notation
ML	Machine Learning
NLP	Natural Language Processing
PDF	Portable Document Format
REST	Representational State Transfer
ROC	Receiver Operating Characteristic
SHAP	Shapley Additive exPlanations
SVM	Support Vector Machine
TF-IDF	Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency
TLS	Transport Layer Security
URL	Uniform Resource Locator
XAI	Explainable Artificial Intelligence
XGBoost	Extreme Gradient Boosting

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

Phishing URLs pose a serious threat due to the increasing usage of automated phishing toolkits and domain generation algorithms that allow attackers to dynamically generate convincing phishing URLs that mimic legitimate web resources. Such deceptive URLs are distributed via email and social media, targeting unwary users and embedding risks of compromised credentials, impersonation, financial theft, system compromise, and privacy violations. The problem is exacerbated by the fact that phishing URLs often appear in the wild long after being created and thus are not covered by traditional signature-based tools or static blacklists. This project introduces ShieldPhish, a hybrid phishing URL detection system that combines heuristic and machine learning-based detection capabilities. Unlike existing solutions, ShieldPhish provides enhanced threat transparency by design, allowing end-users to review the security report with human-readable phishing susceptibility assessment rules. ShieldPhish operates as a complete infrastructure for phishing URL detection, providing an end-to-end pipeline that consists of dataset preparation, feature engineering, model training and selection, and model interpretation. The system utilizes an extended set of relevant features, namely lexicon-based, security-related, statistical, Shannon entropy-based, and character-based TF-IDF features extracted from the URL to be evaluated. The feature set is then processed using multiple classifiers, including Random Forest, XGBoost, Calibrated Linear SVM, and a custom NumPy-based Logistic Regression Classifier, in order to select the optimal model performance. The chosen classifier is then combined with six additional heuristic-based rules and SHAP explainers in order to enhance detection performance and provide interpretability, enabling users to understand phishing detection logic. Finally, a web interface is implemented in order to demonstrate the working prototype of the system, which is deployed as a FastAPI backend with a frontend web UI providing real-time URL assessment and explanation capabilities. Overall, the described system aims to facilitate phishing URL detection research by offering a streamlined, accurate, and high-performance phishing URL detection pipeline with strong model transparency and explainability.

1.2 Problem Statement

Phishing attacks have evolved from simple spam emails to sophisticated, highly targeted cyber campaigns that leverage dynamic domain generation algorithms (DGAs), automated phishing toolkits, and complex URL obfuscation techniques. Modern attackers frequently register transient domains or manipulate URL parameters to closely mimic legitimate web

services, tricking users into disclosing sensitive authentication credentials, personal data, and financial information.

Detecting malicious URLs effectively in real world operational environments presents three primary technical challenges:

Temporal Lag of Static Blacklists

Conventional perimeter defenses heavily rely on domain and URL blacklists (e.g., Phish-Tank, Google Safe Browsing). However, modern phishing campaigns utilize short lived URLs that remain active for only a short period before being abandoned or replaced. Consequently, blacklists suffer from severe temporal lag, leaving users entirely unprotected during the critical initial window of an attack (the "zero day" gap).

Opacity and Brittle Generalization of Standalone ML

Supervised machine learning (ML) classifiers (such as Random Forest and XGBoost) achieve high accuracy on historical training datasets. However, pure ML solutions typically operate as opaque "black boxes." Security Operations Center (SOC) analysts cannot easily inspect or verify the underlying decision logic of an ML prediction. Furthermore, statistical models may exhibit reduced generalization performance when encountering previously unseen or adversarially modified URL patterns, increasing the likelihood of false negative predictions.

Inflexible Determinism of Rule Engines

Static heuristic rule engines assess structural anomalies (e.g., IP addresses in place of domain names, missing HTTPS protocols, or excessive subdomain depth). While rule engines offer low latency, deterministic threat scores, they lack adaptability. Attackers may circumvent static heuristic rules by modifying URL strings (e.g., acquiring free SSL certificates to enable HTTPS), while strict rule engines frequently trigger high false positive rates on complex, legitimate enterprise URLs. To address these challenges, this project proposes ShieldPhish, a hybrid phishing URL detection framework that combines deterministic heuristic reasoning with supervised machine learning and SHAP based Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI). By integrating lightweight rule based analysis with statistical learning, the proposed system aims to improve detection robustness, reduce false negatives, and provide transparent, human-interpretable explanations for every prediction.

1.3 Objectives

The main objective of the project is:

- To design and implement ShieldPhish, a hybrid phishing URL detection system, to classify input URLs as legitimate or phishing using a combination of machine learning, heuristic rule analysis, and Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI), and to assess the performance of the system using standard evaluation criteria.

1.4 Scope and Limitation

1.4.1 Scope

The scope of the ShieldPhish project encompasses the following areas:

- **Static URL Analysis:** The system focuses on evaluating raw text URL strings without requiring active network connections, live web crawling, or sandbox execution environments.
- **Feature Extraction:** Feature extraction is bounded to four core categories extracted directly from raw URL strings: lexical structures, security indicators, information theoretic Shannon entropy, and character level TFIDF representations.
- **Machine Learning Classifiers:** Model evaluation is limited to four supervised algorithms: Random Forest, XGBoost, Calibrated Linear SVM, and a custom NumPy based Logistic Regression baseline.
- **Heuristic Rule Based Detection:** Integration of a heuristic rule engine that evaluates structural threat patterns (such as missing HTTPS, @ symbols, suspicious keywords, excessive length, IP address hostnames, and subdomain counts).
- **Model Interpretability (XAI):** Feature attribution using SHAP to provide real time, feature level diagnostic explanations for every prediction.
- **Web-Based Prototype:** System deployment as a working prototype consisting of a FastAPI backend, React based frontend, and Streamlit diagnostic dashboard.

1.4.2 Limitations

The current implementation of the system has the following limitations:

- **No Live Web Content / DOM Inspection:** The system performs static URL string analysis only. It does not fetch live webpage HTML DOM trees, inspect SSL/TLS certificates, execute JavaScript, or analyze visual website screenshots.
- **Unfollowed Redirection Chains:** While URL shortening services are flagged by the rule engine, the system does not resolve HTTP redirect chains in real time to inspect the final destination landing page.
- **Homograph & Encoding Evasion:** Advanced Internationalized Domain Name (IDN) homograph attacks or extreme percent-encoded strings may circumvent basic character tokenizers.
- **Dependence on Static Lexical Signal:** Phishing attacks hosted on legitimate compromised domains without introducing structural URL anomalies cannot be easily detected using lexical features alone.

1.5 Development Methodology

The proposed framework was developed following an iterative research methodology based on the Cross Industry Standard Process for Data Mining (CRISP-DM). The CRISP DM framework was selected because phishing URL detection is inherently a data-centric cybersecurity problem requiring iterative cycles of data preparation, feature engineering, model refinement, and empirical evaluation. Unlike sequential software development models, CRISP DM facilitates incremental optimization driven by experimental evidence, making it exceptionally well suited for hybrid machine learning systems.

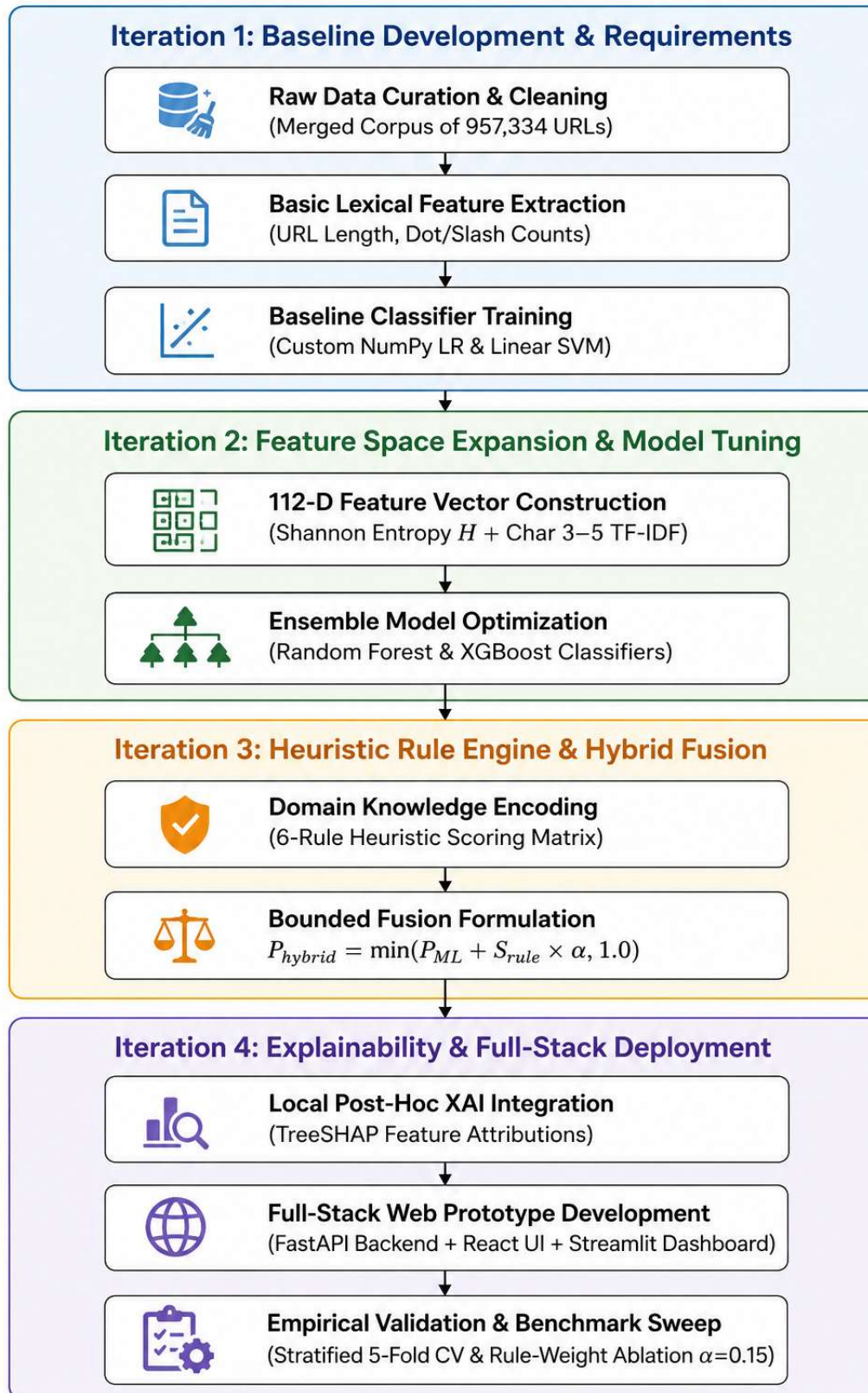


Figure 1.1: Iterative Development

Iterative Development Phases of ShieldPhish:

Iteration 1: Baseline Establishment Baseline requirements were established, the raw dataset was curated and deduplicated, and initial structural lexical features were extracted. Baseline classifiers including a custom NumPy based Logistic Regression model and a Linear Support Vector Machine were implemented to establish baseline predictive performance.

Iteration 2: Feature Space Expansion This phase focused on improving the discriminative capability of the feature representation through the incorporation of information theoretic and textual descriptors. The feature space was expanded to 112 dimensions by integrating Shannon entropy calculations and character level TF IDF n grams, after which Random Forest and XGBoost ensemble classifiers were trained and hyperparameter tuned.

Iteration 3: Hybrid Fusion Integration To enhance system robustness against zero day URL evasions, a deterministic heuristic inference module was introduced to complement statistical prediction by encoding domain knowledge associated with high risk URL structures. These heuristic penalty scores were dynamically combined with machine learning probability predictions through a bounded fusion equation:

$$P_{\text{hybrid}} = \min(P_{\text{ML}} + S_{\text{rule}}, \alpha, 1.0)$$

Iteration 4: Explainability & Prototype Deployment Local posthoc explainability was incorporated through TreeSHAP to generate feature level attribution scores, enabling analysts to inspect the contribution of individual URL characteristics to each prediction. A full-stack web-based prototype consisting of a FastAPI backend, React frontend, and Streamlit diagnostic dashboard was integrated to demonstrate real-time threat evaluation.

System Validation

The proposed framework was validated through stratified cross validation, rule-weight sensitivity analysis, and performance benchmarking to evaluate predictive accuracy, robustness, interpretability, and computational efficiency across successive development iterations.

1.6 Report Organization

Chapter 1: Introduction

This chapter introduces the project, defines the problem, states the objectives, explains scope and limitations, and describes the development methodology.

Chapter 2: Background Study and Literature Review

This chapter discusses the concepts required for phishing URL detection and reviews related research works to identify the research and implementation gap.

Chapter 3: System Analysis

This chapter presents requirement analysis, feasibility analysis, and the analysis models used to understand system processes and data flow.

Chapter 4: System Design

This chapter explains the proposed system design, working mechanism, diagrams, and the algorithm level steps used in the system.

Chapter 5: Implementation and Testing

This chapter describes the tools used, module wise implementation details, testing strategy with test cases, and result analysis.

Chapter 6: Conclusion and Future Recommendations

This chapter concludes the project based on the results obtained and provides future recommendations.

CHAPTER 2

BACKGROUND STUDY AND LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Background Study

The rapid expansion of Internet technologies has transformed communication, financial transactions, cloud services, and digital commerce while simultaneously increasing exposure to sophisticated cyber threats. Among these threats, phishing remains one of the most prevalent forms of cybercrime, exploiting human trust to steal sensitive information such as login credentials, banking details, and personal data through deceptive websites and communication channels. Phishing attacks have evolved considerably from simple spam emails to highly sophisticated campaigns that employ techniques such as Domain Generation Algorithms (DGAs), URL shortening services, homograph attacks, fast flux hosting, free SSL/TLS certificates, and automated phishing toolkits. These techniques enable attackers to generate convincing phishing websites that closely resemble legitimate services while evading traditional detection mechanisms, making malicious URLs increasingly difficult to identify. Traditional phishing detection primarily relies on blacklist services such as Google Safe Browsing and PhishTank. Although effective against previously reported threats, blacklist based approaches cannot detect newly emerging phishing URLs before they are added to threat intelligence databases, creating a critical zero day detection gap. To overcome this limitation, researchers have increasingly adopted machine learning techniques such as Logistic Regression, Support Vector Machines (SVM), Random Forest, and XGBoost, which learn discriminative patterns from URL features. However, these models often operate as black boxes and may exhibit reduced generalization when confronted with previously unseen phishing strategies. Heuristic or rule based detection methods provide fast and interpretable assessments by evaluating suspicious URL characteristics, including abnormal URL length, excessive subdomains, embedded IP addresses, and missing HTTPS protocols. While computationally efficient, static heuristic rules lack adaptability and may produce higher false positive rates when attackers modify URL structures or use legitimate security certificates. Recent research has therefore focused on hybrid phishing detection frameworks that integrate heuristic reasoning with machine learning to improve detection accuracy and

robustness. Furthermore, Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) techniques, particularly SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations), have enhanced model transparency by providing feature level explanations that enable analysts to understand the reasoning behind machine learning predictions. Motivated by these challenges, this project proposes Shield-Phish, a hybrid phishing URL detection framework that combines heuristic rule based analysis, supervised machine learning, and SHAP based explainability. By integrating de-

terministic rule analysis with statistical learning, the proposed framework aims to improve detection accuracy, strengthen robustness against evolving phishing attacks, and provide transparent decision support suitable for real world cybersecurity applications.

2.2 Literature Review

Research in phishing URL detection has evolved rapidly over the past five years, transitioning from static blacklist lookup services to supervised machine learning, deep neural network architectures, hybrid rule fusion, and explainable artificial intelligence (XAI). This section synthesizes recent state of the art research (2021–2025) across these primary paradigms to contextualize the proposed research.

Lexical Feature-Based Detection

Static analysis techniques extract structural and lexical characteristics directly from URL strings without performing live web crawling or network requests. Ma et al. [1] established foundational work showing that lightweight lexical properties such as domain length, path metrics, and special character frequencies can effectively distinguish malicious URLs from benign ones. Building on this foundation, Al Sarem et al. [2] analyzed high-dimensional lexical feature spaces, confirming that structural ratio indicators (such as digit to length and special character density) significantly improve classification accuracy across diverse web domains. Akanho et al. [9] proposed an advanced lexical feature selection framework, demonstrating that character-level tokenization remains a vital first line defense against obfuscated URL paths. AlEryani et al. [10] conducted a high dimensional feature space analysis, showing that static lexical signals provide effective real time threat detection without network overhead.

- **Strengths:** Lexical approaches operate at low computational cost and avoid network latency.
- **Limitations:** Standalone lexical analysis relies on historical character distributions and can be circumvented by attackers using legitimate looking domain structures.

Machine Learning & Ensemble Approaches

To capture non linear feature interactions, recent studies focus heavily on tree based ensembles and gradient boosting algorithms. Subasi et al. [3] evaluated ensemble classification frameworks incorporating structural security indicators, demonstrating that combining decision trees with security flags reduces false positives. Chen et al. [4] investigated Extreme Gradient Boosting (XGBoost) for high-throughput URL classification, demonstrating that gradient-boosted decision trees achieve superior evaluation speeds and AUC ROC metrics compared to traditional neural networks. Chaudhary et al. [7] developed multi-layered feature selection strategies, proving that integrating Shannon entropy into feature vectors enhances model stability against imbalanced dataset distributions.

- **Strengths:** Supervised ML algorithms offer high predictive accuracy, fast evaluation speeds, and strong pattern recognition across large datasets.
- **Limitations:** Pure machine learning classifiers function as opaque "black box" models, offering no decision visibility. Furthermore, statistical models may suffer reduced generalization when encountering novel zero day URL evasions.

Deep Learning & Transformer Architectures

To eliminate manual feature engineering, recent literature explores end to end deep learning and transformer language models. Bozkir et al. [5] introduced PhishNet, applying Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) and Long Short Term Memory (LSTM) networks to capture sequential character dependencies in raw URL strings. Maneriker et al. [6] developed URL-tran, leveraging pre-trained Transformer models (BERT) to perform contextual tokenization of URLs without manual feature engineering. Li et al. [11] proposed PhishFormer, a lightweight transformer architecture designed to detect zero day phishing URLs using self attention mechanisms on character n-grams.

- **Strengths:** Deep learning and transformer models automatically extract subtle sequence representations and achieve strong performance on complex strings.
- **Limitations:** Neural architectures require intensive GPU resources, introduce high inference latency, and lack interpretability, making them less suitable for lightweight, real time edge deployment.

Hybrid Detection Frameworks

Recognizing that pure machine learning classifiers remain vulnerable to zero day structural anomalies, recent studies explore hybrid architectures combining deterministic rule reasoning with data driven models. Shirazi et al. [8] proposed a multi tiered threat assessment engine that applied heuristic rule overrides to low-confidence machine learning predictions, establishing that bounded rule weighting preserves high specificity while flagging structural anomalies. Onyeka et al. [13] introduced a hybrid detection framework combining heuristic rule scoring with machine learning classifiers, proving that rule-based penalty overrides significantly reduce false-negative rates on evasive URLs. Zheng et al. [15] presented a hybrid fusion framework demonstrating that combining expert rules with statistical classifiers improves detection robustness against novel zero day attack vectors.

- **Strengths:** Hybrid systems combine the statistical generalization of ML with the deterministic safety net of heuristic rules, improving robustness against evasive threats.
- **Limitations:** Existing hybrid models often lack local feature explainability and are rarely packaged into full-stack, operational web deployments suitable for real-time analysis.

Explainable AI (XAI) in Cybersecurity

A major challenge in deploying machine learning for operational cybersecurity is model opacity, which prevents Security Operations Center (SOC) analysts from validating automated predictions. Saeed et al. [12] evaluated SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) in cyber threat detection, demonstrating that post hoc feature attributions significantly improve analyst trust and streamline incident response. Kumar et al. [14] introduced XAI Phish, demonstrating that TreeSHAP feature attributions can deliver real time, human readable explanations alongside high accuracy machine learning predictions. Zheng et al. [15] further validated XAI integration in 2025, confirming that local feature attributions bridge the gap between automated classification and operational security auditing.

- **Strengths:** Explainable AI provides transparent, human interpretable feature attributions for complex, opaque machine learning models.
- **Limitations:** XAI methods are post hoc interpretability tools; when used in isolation without rule based safeguards, they explain predictions but do not prevent classification errors caused by zero day evasions.

Table 2.1: Summary of Existing Literature (2021–2025)

Study	Approach	Primary Strengths	Main Limitations
Subasi et al. [3] (2021)	Hybrid Ensemble + Heuristic Rules	Reduces false negatives on evasive URLs	Fixed rule weighting; no post hoc XAI
Chen et al. [4] (2021)	XGBoost + Character Features	Superior speed and AUC ROC metrics	Black box model; lacks interpretability
Bozkir et al. [5] (2021)	PhishNet (Char Level LSTMs)	Learns sequential character patterns	High computational latency
Maneriker [6] (2021)	URLtran (BERT Transformers)	High context learning on complex strings	High parameter count; slow inference speed
Shirazi et al. [8] (2022)	Bounded Heuristic Fusion	Safety overrides for low-confidence ML	Lacks post hoc XAI feature attributions
Li et al. [11] (2023)	PhishFormer (Lightweight Transformers)	Strong zero day contextual learning	Computationally heavy compared to ML trees
Saeed et al. [12] (2023)	Machine Learning + SHAP XAI	Provides local feature level transparency	Lacks rule based safety overrides
Onyeka et al. [13] (2024)	Hybrid Heuristic ML Mitigation	Reduces false negative rates in real time	Lacks interactive web UI deployment

Study	Approach	Primary Strengths	Main Limitations
Kumar et al. [14] (2024)	XAI Phish (TreeSHAP Interpretability)	Human readable threat attributions	Standalone ML; no rule safety net
Zheng et al. [15] (2025)	Hybrid Fusion + XAI Frameworks	Robust zero day threat scoring	High structural complexity

Research Gap

Although recent studies (2021–2025) have demonstrated substantial improvements in phishing URL detection, no single approach simultaneously provides high predictive accuracy, computational efficiency, deterministic rule based verification, and interpretable decision support. Deep learning models often achieve excellent performance but incur significant computational overhead, while conventional machine learning approaches generally lack transparency and may struggle with previously unseen phishing attacks. Likewise, heuristic systems provide explainable decisions but suffer from limited adaptability. These limitations motivate the development of a hybrid framework that combines machine learning, deterministic heuristic reasoning, and Explainable Artificial Intelligence within a unified, high throughput detection pipeline.

CHAPTER 3

SYSTEM ANALYSIS

3.1 System Analysis

The ShieldPhish detection system is analyzed in order to ascertain whether or not the proposed solution is feasible and clear in its description before proceeding to design in detail. This is a crucial phase in which one is required to identify what is to be done by the system, what quality is to be satisfied by the system, whether or not the project is feasible, and how the system is to be analyzed using appropriate system analysis techniques.

3.1.1 Requirement Analysis

Requirement analysis is a fundamental step in software and system engineering that defines the necessary behavior, constraints, and quality attributes of the proposed framework. For ShieldPhish, requirements are divided into Functional Requirements, which specify the operational tasks the system must perform, and non functional requirements, which define quality attributes such as performance, accuracy, transparency, and scalability.

Functional Requirement

The functional requirements define the core functionalities that the proposed ShieldPhish system must provide to support phishing URL detection and analysis.

URL Input Processing:

The system shall accept URL inputs through an interactive web interface, REST API requests, and batch processing for phishing detection.

Feature Extraction:

The system shall automatically extract relevant lexical, security-related, statistical, and character-level textual features from the input URL to generate the feature representation required for classification.

Phishing Detection:

The system shall classify the input URL as Legitimate or Phishing using trained supervised machine learning models.

Heuristic Risk Analysis:

The system shall evaluate the input URL using predefined heuristic rules to identify suspicious structural characteristics and calculate a heuristic risk score.

Hybrid Decision Making:

The system shall combine machine learning predictions with heuristic risk analysis to produce the final phishing detection result.

Explainable Prediction:

The system shall generate feature-level explanations using SHAP Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) to identify the factors contributing to each prediction.

Result Presentation:

The system shall display the predicted URL classification, confidence score, heuristic analysis, and explanation through the web interface and REST API.

Analytical Dashboard:

The system shall provide a dashboard for visualizing prediction statistics, feature importance, and model performance.

API Services:

The system shall expose RESTful API endpoints to allow external applications to submit URLs and retrieve phishing detection results.

Maintain Complete Prediction Workflow

The prediction workflow defines the sequential data processing pipeline executed by Shield-Phish when evaluating an input URL. The system operates via a dual path hybrid architecture, processing statistical machine learning and deterministic heuristic rules concurrently before fusing the outputs and extracting TreeSHAP explainability attributions.

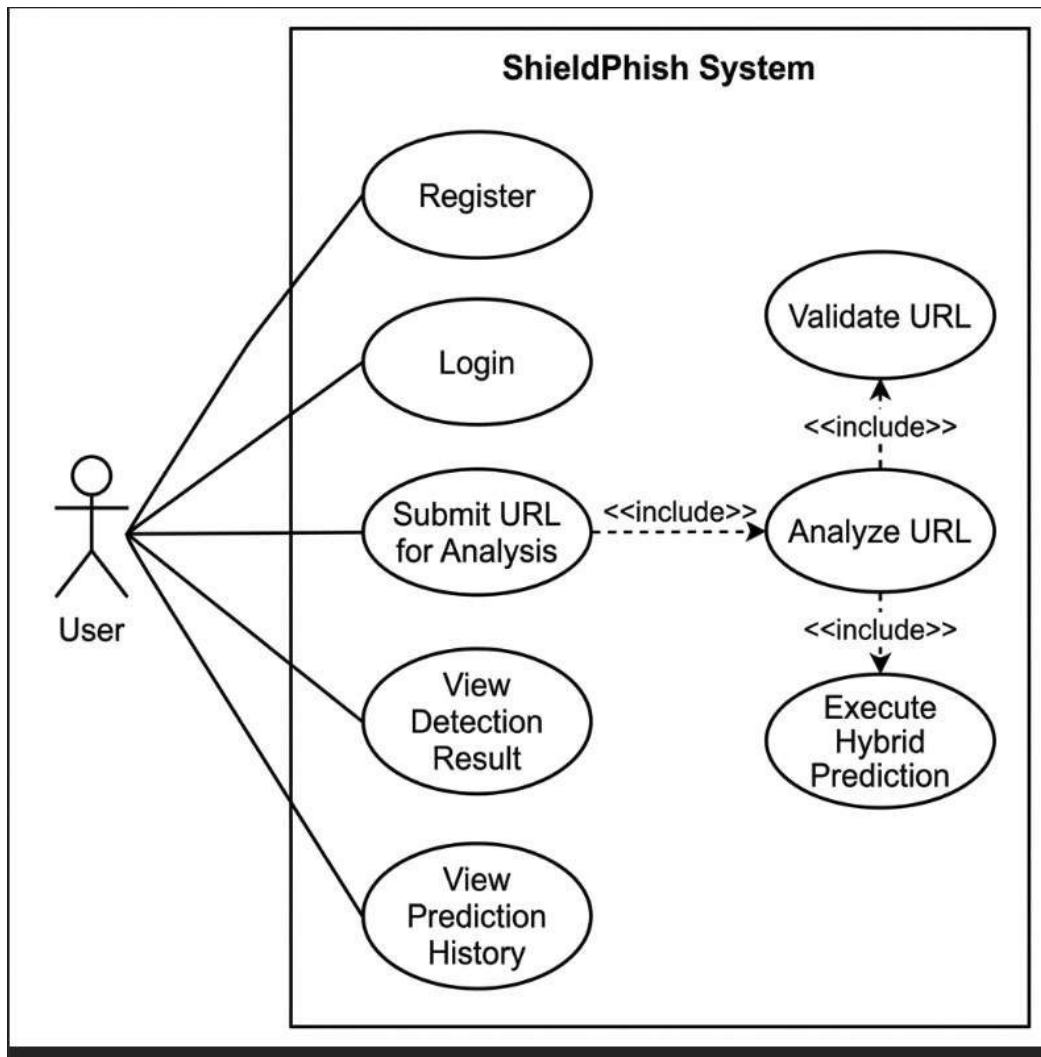


Figure 3.1: Use Case Diagram

The use case diagram shows the functional boundaries of the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System from the user’s perspective. The primary actor in this system is the User (Security Analyst), who interacts with the system to perform authentication, submit URLs for threat analysis, view detection results, and retrieve historical query records. The core workflow begins with the analyst registering an account and logging into the system dashboard. To inspect a target URL, the analyst executes the Submit URL for Analysis use case. This action incorporates (<<include>>) the Analyze URL sub-process, which further includes the Validate URL use case (to perform syntax, format, and length checks) and the Execute Hybrid Prediction use case (to run the feature extraction, heuristic evaluation, and bounded fusion model). Once the detection pipeline finishes, the analyst can access the View Detection Result use case to inspect the hybrid risk score and TreeSHAP attributions, or invoke the View Prediction History use case to audit past prediction logs.

Non Functional Requirement

Non-functional requirements define the quality attributes, performance constraints, operational benchmarks, and system qualities that ShieldPhish must satisfy.

Performance & Sub-Millisecond Inference Latency

The system shall process raw URLs, extract 112 features, calculate hybrid probability predictions, and generate TreeSHAP attributions with sub-millisecond execution latency (**< 1 ms per URL**). This ensures suitability for high-throughput network perimeter inspection and real-time proxy integration.

Predictive Accuracy & Generalization Robustness

The primary machine learning classifiers shall maintain benchmark classification performance under 5-fold stratified cross-validation on held-out evaluation datasets: Random Forest: $\geq 95.0\%$ Accuracy

XGBoost: $\geq 94.3\%$ Accuracy and ≥ 0.983 ROC-AUC score

The bounded hybrid fusion engine ($\alpha = 0.15$) shall mitigate false negatives on zero-day URLs containing distinct structural threat anomalies.

System Transparency & Model Interpretability

100% of automated classification predictions shall be accompanied by local feature attributions generated via TreeSHAP. The system shall convert mathematical Shapley values into the top 5 human-readable diagnostic reasons, eliminating black-box decision opacity for Security Operations Center (SOC) analysts.

Resource Efficiency & High-Throughput Scalability

The backend server (FastAPI) shall execute efficiently on standard single-core or multi-core CPU architecture without requiring expensive GPU hardware acceleration. The asynchronous REST API shall support concurrent HTTP requests without memory leaks or degradation of inference speed.

System Reliability & Fault Tolerance

The system shall gracefully handle malformed, non-standard, percent-encoded, or extremely long URL inputs. If optional SHAP explainer modules are unavailable for non-tree models, the system shall degrade gracefully by serving the hybrid prediction score without backend crashes.

Portability & Runtime Environment Compatibility

The codebase shall be fully portable, operating across Linux, macOS, and Windows operating systems. The application stack shall run within standard Python 3.9+ environments utilizing open-source dependencies (scikit-learn, xgboost, shap, FastAPI, React, Streamlit).

3.1.2 Feasibility Analysis

A feasibility study is a critical evaluation conducted during the system analysis phase to ascertain whether the proposed ShieldPhish framework can be successfully developed, evaluated, and deployed. The analysis assesses the project across four primary dimensions: Technical Feasibility, Operational Feasibility, Economic Feasibility, and Schedule Feasibility.

Technical Feasibility

Technical feasibility evaluates whether the required hardware, software infrastructure, and machine learning algorithms are available and capable of meeting system objectives:

- **Open-Source Software Infrastructure:** The proposed framework is implemented using mature, open-source technologies that provide reliable support for machine learning, explainable AI, API development, and web application deployment. These technologies have extensive community support, active maintenance, and proven scalability, making them suitable for developing the proposed phishing URL detection framework.
- **Hardware & Resource Efficiency:** Feature engineering, hybrid fusion, and TreeSHAP attribution calculations execute efficiently on standard single-core or multi-core CPU architectures without requiring expensive GPU hardware acceleration.
- **Computational Efficiency:** The proposed framework performs feature extraction and prediction efficiently on standard CPU hardware, enabling near real-time phishing URL detection suitable for operational network security applications.

Operational Feasibility

Operational feasibility assesses how effectively the proposed solution fits into real world operational workflows and whether end-users can utilize the system easily:

- **Model Interpretability & Decision Transparency:** Traditional machine learning models produce probability scores that are difficult for security analysts to interpret. ShieldPhish addresses this limitation by incorporating TreeSHAP local feature attributions, converting mathematical Shapley values into human-readable diagnostic reasons.
- **SOC Analyst Usability:** Security Operations Center (SOC) analysts can inspect threat reports, view top contributing feature attributions, and review triggered heuristic rules without requiring deep machine learning expertise.
- **Multi-Interface Deployment:** The system provides an interactive React web interface for real-time URL scanning, a Streamlit diagnostic dashboard for model analytics, and a FastAPI REST API for automated security proxy integration.

Economic Feasibility

Economic feasibility evaluates the financial viability, cost structure, and infrastructure requirements of the project:

- **Cost Effectiveness:** The proposed system relies entirely on open-source software technologies under permissive software licenses. Consequently, system development and deployment incur zero commercial licensing fees.
- **Low Infrastructure Footprint:** Because the framework is optimized for CPU execution rather than high-end GPU clusters, operational hosting and hardware maintenance costs remain minimal.
- **Public Threat Intelligence Datasets:** Model training and evaluation utilize publicly available cybersecurity datasets compiled from PhishTank and Kaggle, incurring zero data acquisition expenditure.

Schedule Feasibility

Schedule feasibility determines whether the project can be completed within the allocated timeframe:

CRISP-DM Iterative Execution: The project followed an iterative development process based on the CRISP-DM framework, with clearly defined milestones for data preparation, feature engineering, model development, evaluation, explainability integration, and application deployment. The planned activities were completed within the allocated project duration.

Table 3.1: Gantt Chart

Activities/Duration	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Week 5	Week 6	Week 7	Week 8	Week 9	Week 10
Planning										
Research										
Data Gathering										
Requirement Analysis										
Coding										
Testing										
Validation										
Documentation										

3.2 Analysis

The proposed ShieldPhish system can be analyzed using an object-oriented approach because the system consists of different modular entities and classes that interact with each other. The major components of the system include the user/analyst, URL input, Feature Extractor module, Rule Engine module, Hybrid Phishing Model estimator, Trees HAP explainer, and result output interface. Object-oriented analysis helps to represent the system using structural and behavioral UML diagrams such as the Class Diagram, Sequence Diagram,

and Activity Diagram which illustrate the internal static structure, dynamic behavior, and operational workflow of the proposed framework.

Object modelling using Class and Object Diagrams

Object modeling represents the static structure of the proposed ShieldPhish Phishing UR-Detection System. It identifies the major classes, objects, attributes, operations, and relationships involved in the system. In this project, the main classes include User, Admin, Feature Extractor, Rule Engine, Hybrid Phishing Model, Logistic Regression Scratch, Fast API Controller, and Threat Report. The object model helps to describe how different components of the system are connected with each other and shows how a user submits a URL string, how the URL is validated and converted into a 112-dimensional feature vector, how the trained machine learning classifier and 6-rule heuristic engine perform dual-path hybrid prediction, and how the final threat assessment result and TreeSHAP XAI attributions are generated.

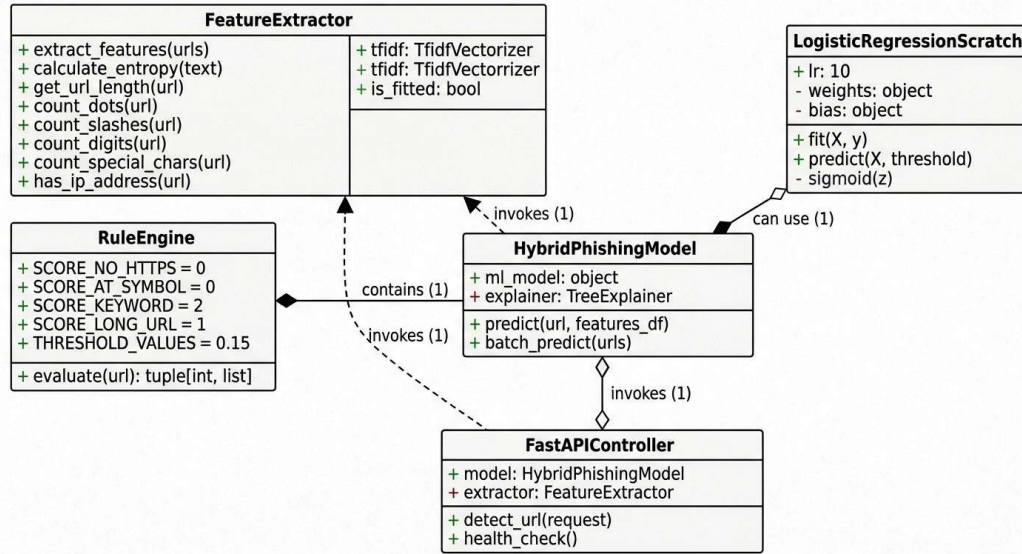


Figure 3.2: Class Diagram

The class diagram illustrates the static architecture of the proposed ShieldPhish system. The Fast API Controller serves as the primary API gateway, orchestrating user requests and routing data to the core analytical components: the Feature Extractor, Rule Engine, and Hybrid Phishing Model. The Feature Extractor parses the input URL string to generate a comprehensive 112-dimensional feature vector, while the Rule Engine concurrently evaluates predefined heuristic conditions to compute an integer threat penalty score (Srule). The Hybrid Phishing Model then integrates the statistical machine learning probability (PML) with the heuristic penalty using a bounded fusion function to output the final classification confidence (Phybrid). To ensure interpretability, the Tree Explainer generates SHAP-based local feature attributions. The complete detection payload including the prediction, confidence, and explanatory factors is then encapsulated within the Threat Report. Overall, the

diagram accurately maps the static dependencies and structural relationships required for full-stack feature extraction, hybrid detection, explainability, and threat reporting.

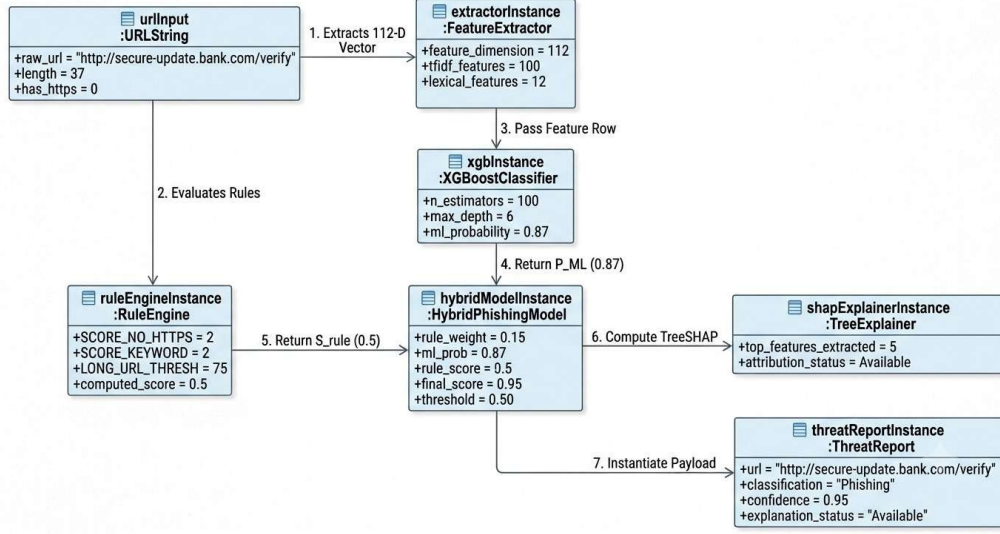


Figure 3.3: Object Diagram

The object diagram illustrates a runtime snapshot of the ShieldPhish system during a single phishing URL detection process. The url Input: URL String object submits the input URL, which is processed simultaneously by the Feature Extractor to generate a 112-dimensional feature vector and by the Rule Engine to compute the heuristic penalty score ($S_{rule} = 0.5$). The extracted features are then classified by the XGBoost Classifier, producing a phishing probability ($P_{ML} = 0.87$). The Hybrid Phishing Model combines the machine learning probability and heuristic score to calculate the final hybrid confidence ($P_{hybrid} = 0.95$) and determine the final classification. The Tree Explainer generates SHAP-based feature attributions for interpretability, while the Threat Report object stores the final prediction, confidence score, and explanation. Overall, the diagram demonstrates the interaction among system objects during feature extraction, hybrid classification, explainability, and report generation.

Dynamic Modelling Using State and Sequence Diagrams

Dynamic modeling shows the behavior of the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System during execution. It explains how the system changes its state and how different objects interact with each other during the phishing URL detection and explainability process. In this project, dynamic modeling is represented using the State Diagram and Sequence Diagram.

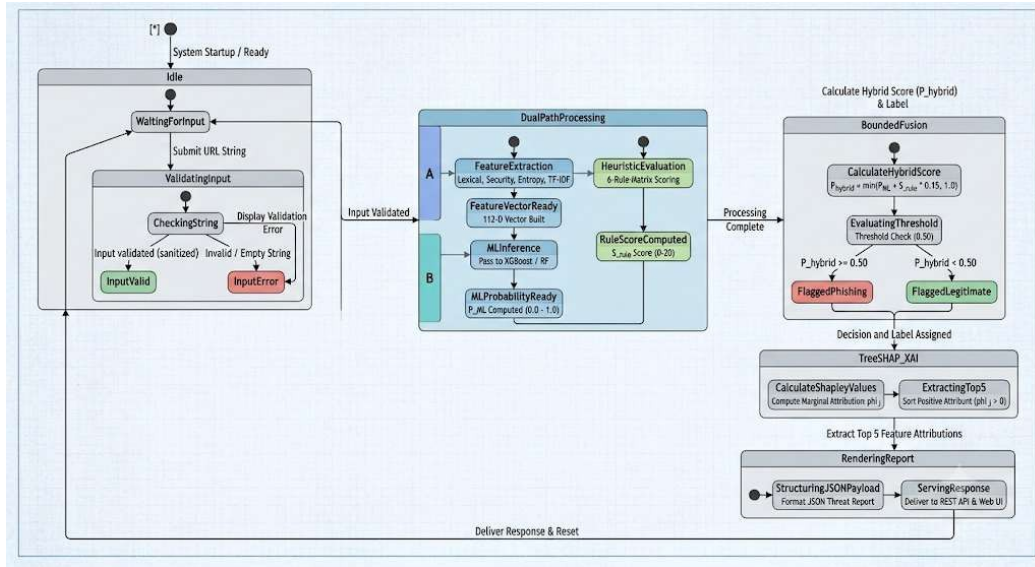


Figure 3.4: State Diagram

When a user submits a URL string, the input first enters the Submitted state. The system then validates the URL string format and length. If the URL is valid, it moves to the Validated state; otherwise, it moves to the Rejected state. After validation, the URL is processed by extracting the 112-dimensional feature vector and concurrently evaluating the 6-rule heuristic matrix. Then, the trained machine learning model and heuristic rule engine perform dual-path hybrid prediction, generating the final classification result as Legitimate or Phishing. Finally, TreeSHAP feature attributions are computed, the prediction record is saved, and a diagnostic threat report is generated. When a user submits a URL string, the input first enters the Submitted state. The system then validates the URL string format and length. If the URL is valid, it moves to the Validated state; otherwise, it moves to the Rejected state. After validation, the URL is processed by extracting the 112-dimensional feature vector and concurrently evaluating the 6-rule heuristic matrix. Then, the trained machine learning model and heuristic rule engine perform dual-path hybrid prediction, generating the final classification result as Legitimate or Phishing. Finally, TreeSHAP feature attributions are computed, the prediction record is saved, and a diagnostic threat report is generated.

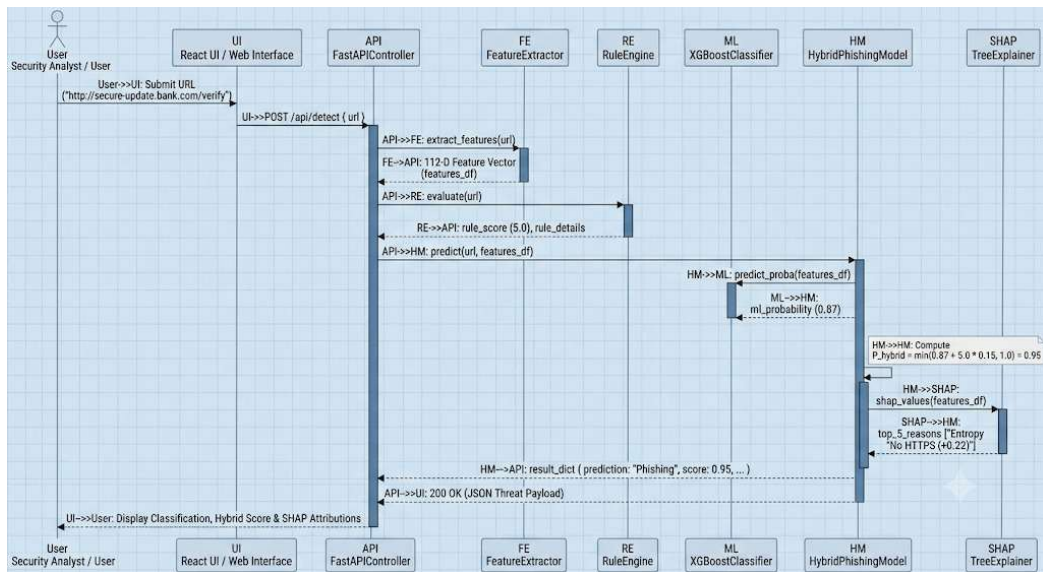


Figure 3.5: Sequence Diagram

The sequence diagram illustrates the interaction among the components of the ShieldPhish system during a phishing URL detection request. The process begins when the user submits a URL through the React web interface, which forwards the request to the FastAPI Controller. The controller invokes the Feature Extractor to generate a 112-dimensional feature vector and the Rule Engine to compute the heuristic penalty score. The extracted features are then passed to the XGBoost classifier through the Hybrid Phishing Model to estimate the machine learning phishing probability. The Hybrid Phishing Model combines the ML probability with the heuristic score to calculate the final hybrid confidence score. Subsequently, the TreeSHAP Explainer generates feature-level explanations, and the Hybrid Phishing Model prepares the threat report. Finally, the API returns the classification result, confidence score, and SHAP explanations to the user interface for display.

Process Modelling Using Activity Diagram

Process modeling represents the workflow of the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System. It shows the sequence of activities performed from the time a user submits a URL string until the final threat prediction, TreeSHAP attributions, and diagnostic report are displayed.

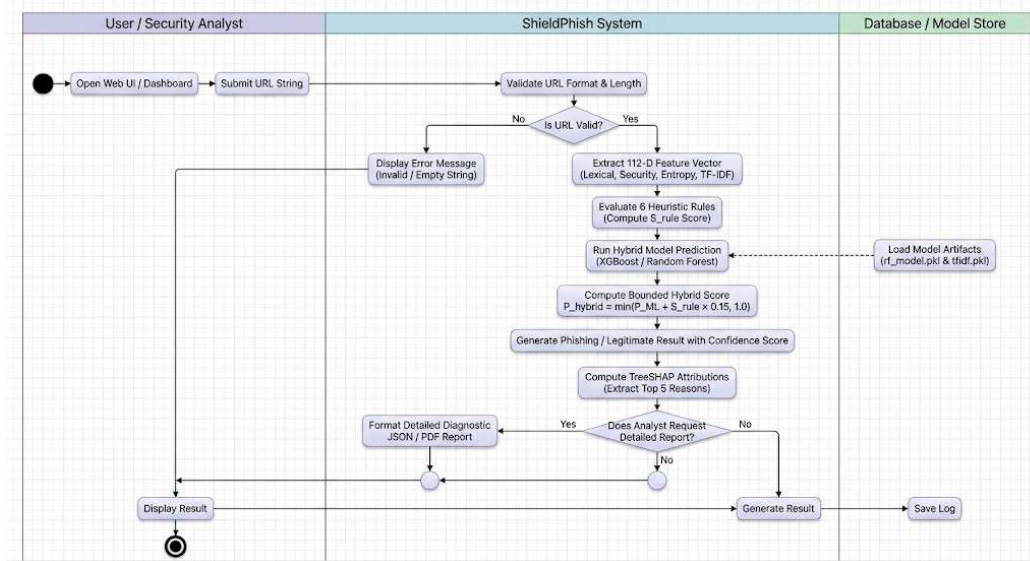


Figure 3.6: Activity Diagram

The activity diagram illustrates the operational workflow of the ShieldPhish system by separating responsibilities among the User/Security Analyst, the ShieldPhish System, and the Database/Model Store. The process begins when the user submits a URL through the web interface. The system validates the input and, if valid, extracts a 112-dimensional feature vector, evaluates heuristic rules, performs hybrid machine learning prediction, and computes the final phishing confidence score. TreeSHAP then generates feature-level explanations, after which the system prepares either a standard or detailed threat report based on the user's request. Finally, the detection result is displayed to the user, and the prediction log is stored in the database.

CHAPTER 4

SYSTEM DESIGN

4.1 Design

System design describes how the proposed ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System is organized and how different components of the system work together. Since this project follows an object-oriented approach, the design focuses on the refinement of system modules, user interface, database/model store, component structure, deployment structure, and algorithm details. The proposed system is designed as a web-based application where the user can submit URL strings, and the system automatically predicts whether the URL is Legitimate or Phishing using a hybrid fusion of machine learning and heuristic rule analysis. The system includes a frontend interface (React), backend server (Fast API), feature engineering module, trained machine learning model, 6-rule heuristic engine, TreeSHAP explainability module, database/model store, and Streamlit diagnostic dashboard. This chapter presents the refinement of the Class Diagram, Object Diagram, State Diagram, Sequence Diagram, and Activity Diagram, along with algorithm-level procedural steps and deployment architecture.

Refinement of Class, Object, State, Sequence and Activity diagrams

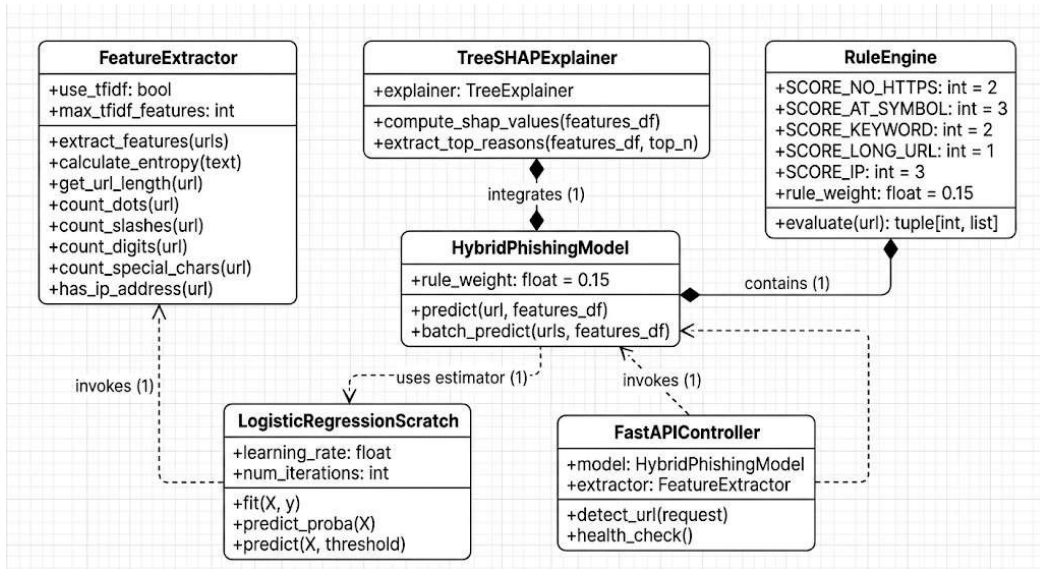


Figure 4.1: Refinement of Class Diagram

The refined class diagram shows the main classes of the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System and their relationships. The Fast API Controller class acts as the central API gateway, handling incoming detection requests and system health checks. The security analyst submits URL strings and views diagnostic threat reports, while the administrator manages trained

model artifacts, TF-IDF vectorizers, and threshold parameters. The submitted URL is processed by the Feature Extractor class to generate a 112-dimensional feature vector. The feature vector and raw URL are sent to Hybrid Phishing Model, which compositionally integrates Rule Engine to evaluate 6 structural risk rules and uses the primary classifier (such as XGBoost, Random Forest, or Logistic Regression Scratch) to compute statistical probabilities. The combined prediction is passed to TreeSHAP Explainer to extract local feature-level attributions, stored in the threat model store, and formatted by Threat Report to generate a diagnostic threat payload.

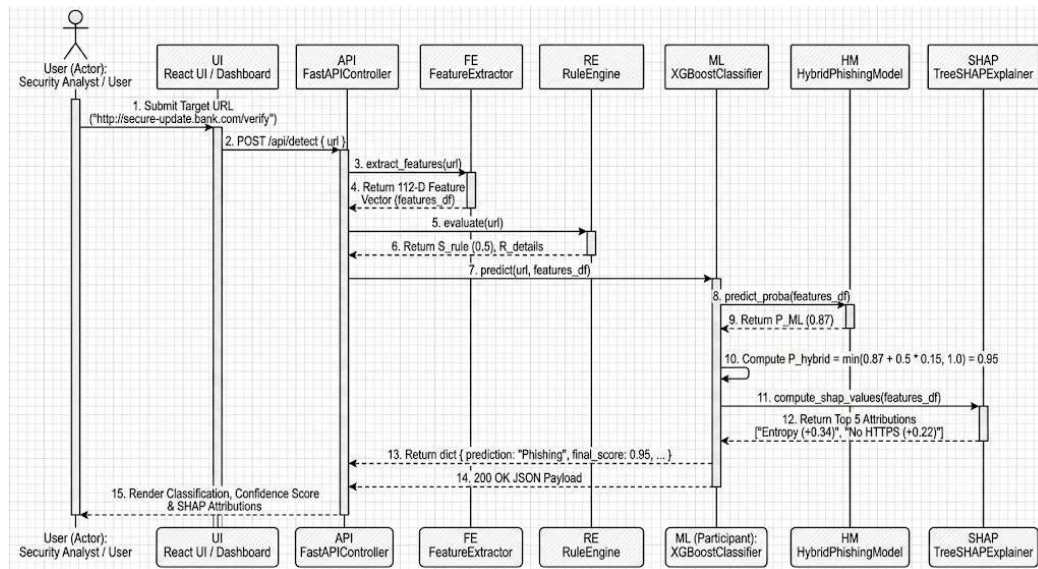


Figure 4.2: Refinement of Sequence Diagram

The sequence diagram illustrates the interaction between the user and the ShieldPhish system during a phishing URL detection request. Initially, the user submits a URL through the React web interface, which sends the request to the Fast API controller. The controller invokes the FeatureExtractor to generate a 112-dimensional feature vector and simultaneously requests the RuleEngine to evaluate heuristic security rules and compute the rule score. The extracted features are then forwarded to the XGBoost classifier, which predicts the machine learning phishing probability (P_{ML}). The HybridPhishingModel combines the machine learning probability with the heuristic rule score using the bounded hybrid fusion equation to calculate the final phishing score (P_{hybrid}). Next, the TreeSHAP Explainer computes feature attributions and identifies the top contributing reasons for the prediction. Finally, the HybridPhishing Model generates a threat report containing the prediction result, confidence score, and SHAP explanations. The Fast API controller returns the response as a JSON payload, and the React web interface displays the phishing classification and explanation to the user.

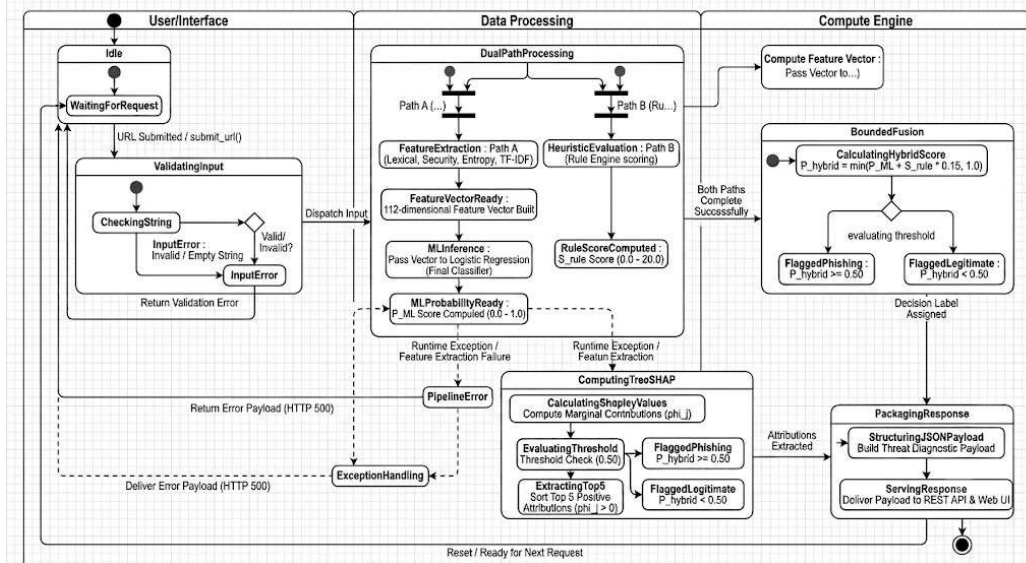


Figure 4.3: Refinement of Activity Diagram

The refined activity diagram illustrates the complete workflow of the ShieldPhish framework utilizing three distinct operational swimlanes: User / Security Analyst, ShieldPhish System, and Database / Model Store. The process initiates when the user opens the dashboard interface and submits a target URL string. The system first validates the URL format and length; if invalid, the execution terminates and an error message is displayed. If the URL is valid, the system preprocesses the string and executes the core analytical pipeline: extracting the 112-dimensional feature vector (encompassing lexical, security, Shannon entropy, and character-level TF-IDF metrics) and evaluating the URL against the 6-rule heuristic matrix. Concurrently, the system loads the pre-trained model artifacts (rf_model.pkl and tfidf.pkl) from the persistent data store. The statistical machine learning probability and the heuristic penalty score are then combined using a bounded fusion function to determine the final classification (Legitimate or Phishing) and the hybrid confidence score (Phybrid). Following classification, TreeSHAP feature attributions are computed to extract the top contributing structural factors. The final prediction record is securely saved to the database for future telemetry. Finally, the flow bifurcates based on user preference: if requested, the system generates a detailed diagnostic JSON or PDF report; otherwise, it returns a standard result display to the user, concluding the process. The refined activity diagram illustrates the complete workflow of the ShieldPhish framework utilizing three distinct operational swimlanes: User / Security Analyst, ShieldPhish System, and Database / Model Store. The process initiates when the user opens the dashboard interface and submits a target URL string. The system first validates the URL format and length; if invalid, the execution terminates and an error message is displayed. If the URL is valid, the system preprocesses the string and executes the core analytical pipeline: extracting the 112-dimensional feature vector (encompassing lexical, security, Shannon entropy, and character-level TF-IDF metrics) and evaluating the URL against the 6-rule heuristic matrix.

Concurrently, the system loads the pre-trained model artifacts (rf_model.pkl and tfidf.pkl) from the persistent data store. The statistical machine learning probability and the heuristic penalty score are then combined using a bounded fusion function to determine the final classification (Legitimate or Phishing) and the hybrid confidence score (phybrid). Following classification, TreeSHAP feature attributions are computed to extract the top contributing structural factors. The final prediction record is securely saved to the database for future telemetry. Finally, the flow bifurcates based on user preference: if requested, the system generates a detailed diagnostic JSON or PDF report; otherwise, it returns a standard result display to the user, concluding the process.

Component Diagram

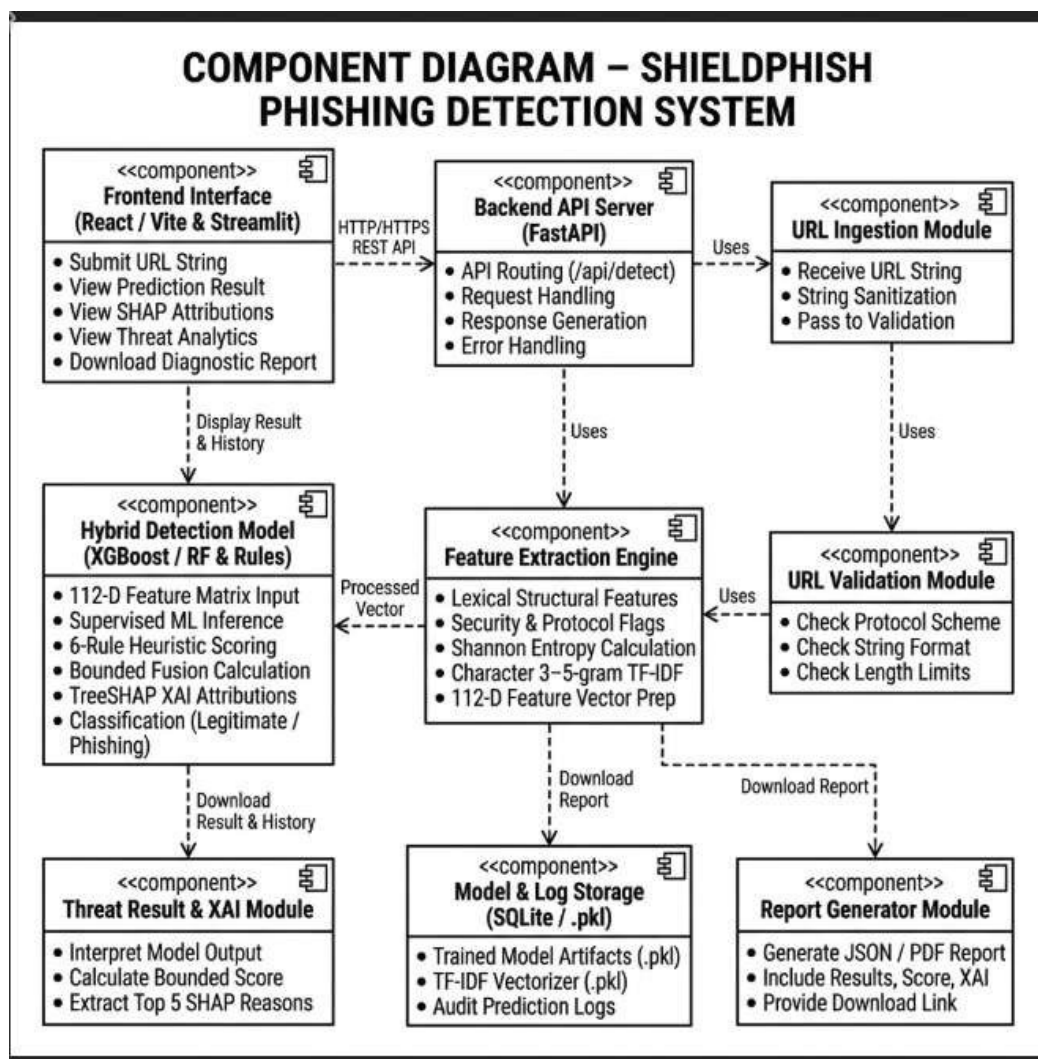


Figure 4.4: Component Diagram

The component diagram shows the main modules of the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System and how they interact. The Frontend Interface (React / Vite & Streamlit) communicates with the Backend API Server (FastAPI) through HTTP/HTTPS REST APIs.

The backend handles API routing (/api/detect), URL ingestion, string validation, feature extraction, hybrid prediction execution, model storage retrieval, and diagnostic report generation. After input validation, the raw URL is sent to the Feature Extraction Engine, which computes the 112-dimensional feature vector. The feature vector is then passed to the Hybrid Detection Model (XGBoost / RF & Rules) for Legitimate/Phishing classification and 6-rule penalty evaluation. The Threat Result & XAI Module generates the final classification label, confidence score (Phybrid), and top 5 TreeSHAP feature attributions, stores the prediction log in Model & Log Storage (SQLite /. pkl), and the Report Generator Module creates a downloadable diagnostic JSON/PDF report.

Deployment Diagram

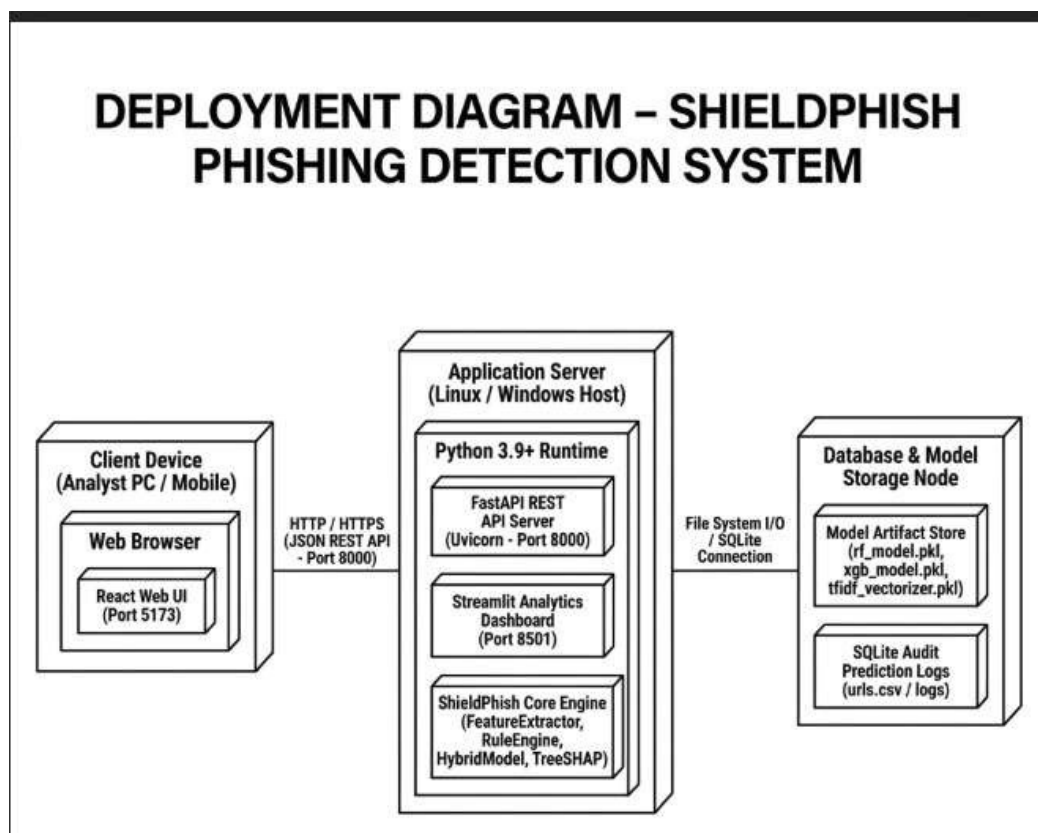


Figure 4.5: Deployment Diagram

The deployment diagram illustrates how the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System is deployed in a client–server environment. A security analyst or administrator accesses the system through a web browser running the React web interface on a client device. The browser communicates with the Fast API application server via HTTP/HTTPS REST APIs to submit URLs and receive phishing detection results. The application server hosts the ShieldPhish core engine, including the Feature Extractor, Rule Engine, Hybrid Phishing Model, and TreeSHAP Explainer, along with the Streamlit analytics dashboard. The server performs URL validation, feature extraction, hybrid prediction, explainability generation,

and report creation. Trained model artifacts, including Random Forest, XGBoost, and the TF IDF vectorizer, are loaded from local storage during inference. A local SQLite database stores prediction audit logs, confidence scores, heuristic rule results, and generated reports. Overall, the deployment diagram illustrates the physical arrangement of the client, application server, and storage components, as well as their interactions during phishing URL detection.

4.2 Algorithms Details

The core framework used in this project is the ShieldPhish Hybrid Feature Extraction, Bounded Rule Fusion, and TreeSHAP Explainability Network. The system is designed to detect phishing URLs by analyzing structural lexical metrics, security protocol flags, information-theoretic Shannon entropy, and character-level TF-IDF n-grams from raw URL strings. Unlike conventional standalone machine learning models that often behave as black-box predictors, the proposed algorithm processes each input through a dual-path pipeline: a 112-dimensional Statistical ML Classifier Stream and a Deterministic 6-Rule Heuristic Engine Stream.

The system accepts a raw URL string as input, represented as a character sequence:

$$U = \{c_1, c_2, \dots, c_N\}, \quad c_i \in \Sigma \quad (1)$$

where N represents the total character length of the URL, and Σ represents the character alphabet (alphanumeric characters, punctuation, and special symbols).

Structural Lexical & Security Feature Extractor

The Structural Lexical and Security Stream processes the URL string directly to extract structural metrics and protocol indicators. These features capture structural anomalies, brand impersonation attempts, and unencrypted transmission schemes.

The structural metrics extract total length, path length, domain length, character counts, and security protocol flags:

$$x_{\text{len}} = |U|, \quad x_{\text{dots}} = \sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{I}(c_i = '.'), \quad x_{\text{slashes}} = \sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{I}(c_i = '/') \quad (2)$$

The digit to length ratio R_{digit} and special character density R_{special} are calculated as:

$$R_{\text{digit}} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{I}(c_i \in \{0, \dots, 9\})}{N} \quad (3)$$

$$R_{\text{special}} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{I}(c_i \in \{ @, ?, =, \%, _ \})}{N} \quad (4)$$

Security flags evaluate protocol and hostname properties:

$$x_{\text{https}} = \mathbb{I}(U \text{ starts with "https://"}) \quad (5)$$

This stream yields a compact 11-dimensional structural vector:

$$\mathbf{x}_{\text{struct}} \in \mathbb{R}^{11} \quad (6)$$

Information Theoretical Shannon Entropy ($\mathcal{H}$) The Shannon Entropy Stream captures character randomness and uncertainty within the URL string. Phishing campaigns generated via Domain Generation Algorithms (DGAs) or hex-encoded session parameters exhibit higher character randomness than legitimate natural-language URLs.

For a URL string U containing unique characters c_i with empirical probability $P(c_i) = \frac{\text{count}(c_i)}{|U|}$,

Shannon Entropy is defined as:

$$\mathcal{H}(U) = - \sum_{i=1}^{|\Sigma|} P(c_i) \log_2 P(c_i) \quad (7)$$

where $\mathcal{H}(U) \in \mathbb{R}$ represents the entropy scalar. Higher values indicate algorithmically generated domain names or obfuscated parameters.

Character Level 3–5-gram TF-IDF Vectorizer

The NLP TF-IDF Stream captures fine-grained sub-word linguistic representations (such as log, ogi, gin for the target term login).

The Term Frequency (TF) and Inverse Document Frequency (IDF) for character n-gram t in URL U across corpus D are defined as:

$$\text{TF}(t, U) = \frac{f_{t,U}}{\sum_{t' \in U} f_{t',U}} \quad (8)$$

$$\text{IDF}(t, D) = \log \left(\frac{1 + |D|}{1 + |\{U \in D : t \in U\}|} \right) + 1 \quad (9)$$

The final TF-IDF feature value is computed as:

$$\mathbf{x}_{\text{tfidf}}(t) = \text{TF}(t, U) \times \text{IDF}(t, D) \in \mathbb{R}^{100} \quad (10)$$

Concatenating all streams produces the full 112-dimensional feature vector:

$$\mathbf{X} = [\mathbf{x}_{\text{struct}} \parallel \mathcal{H}(U) \parallel \mathbf{x}_{\text{tfidf}}] \in \mathbb{R}^{112} \quad (11)$$

Note: The final feature vector consists of 11 handcrafted structural lexical and security features, 1 Shannon entropy feature, and 100 character-level TF-IDF n-gram features,

producing a total dimension of 112.

Supervised ML Probability & 6-Rule Heuristic Engine

The feature vector $\mathbf{X}$ is passed to the trained ensemble classifier (XGBoost / Random Forest) to compute the statistical phishing probability:

$$P_{\text{ML}} = \text{predict_proba}(\mathbf{X})[1] \in [0.0, 1.0] \quad (12)$$

Concurrently, the raw URL string U is evaluated against the 6-rule heuristic engine to calculate an integer penalty score:

$$S_{\text{rule}} = \sum_{k=1}^6 s_k \in [0, 20] \quad (13)$$

where penalty weights are assigned as: $s_1 = 2$ (No HTTPS), $s_2 = 3$ (@ Symbol), $s_3 = 2$. Nkw (Keywords), $s_4 = 1$ (Length > 75), $s_5 = 3$ (IPv4 Host), $s_6 = 1$ (Subdomains > 3).

Bounded Hybrid Fusion & TreeSHAP Explainability

To combine statistical pattern recognition with deterministic safety rules, the system applies the Bounded Hybrid Fusion Formula:

$$P_{\text{hybrid}} = \min(P_{\text{ML}} + S_{\text{rule}}\alpha, 1.0), \quad \alpha = 0.15 \quad (14)$$

The final binary classification label $\hat{y}$ is assigned via:

$$\hat{y} = \begin{cases} \text{Phishing}, & P_{\text{hybrid}} \geq 0.50, \\ \text{Legitimate}, & P_{\text{hybrid}} < 0.50. \end{cases} \quad (15)$$

Finally, local post hoc feature attributions are computed via TreeSHAP:

$$f(\mathbf{X}) = \phi_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{112} \phi_j z'_j \quad (16)$$

where ϕ_0 is the expected baseline model output and ϕ_j represents the marginal contribution of the j -th feature toward the final prediction. Positive attributions ($\phi_j > 0$) are extracted and presented as the top 5 human-readable diagnostic reasons for security analysts.

CHAPTER 5

IMPLEMENTATION AND TESTING

5.1 Implementation

Implementation is the process of converting the system design into a working software application. In this project, the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System is implemented as a web-based application that allows users to submit URL strings and receive a prediction result as Legitimate or Phishing, complete with local TreeSHAP feature attributions and threat metrics. The system uses a hybrid fusion model containing a trained machine learning classifier (Random Forest or XGBoost) saved in binary pickle (.pkl) format, a character level TF IDF vectorizer, and a custom 6 rule heuristic engine. The backend handles URL validation, 112-dimensional feature extraction, heuristic scoring, model loading, bounded probability fusion, TreeSHAP explainability computation, database operations, and diagnostic report generation. The frontend provides a user-friendly interface for URL string submission, threat score visualization, TreeSHAP local attribution charting, and diagnostic report download.

The overall implementation workflow is as follows:

Overall Implementation Workflow

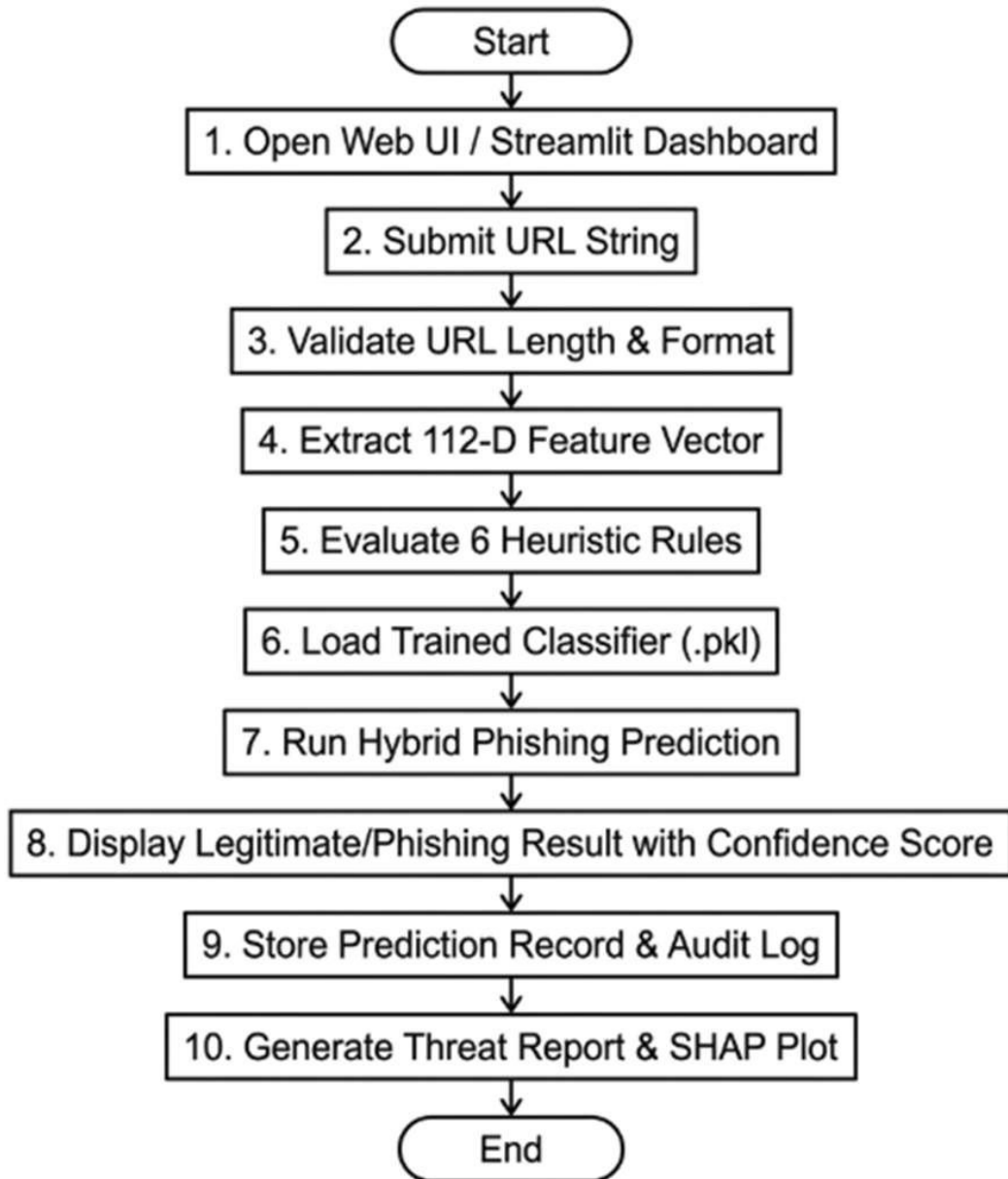


Figure 5.1: Overall Implementation Workflow

5.1.1 Tools Used

The following tools and technologies were used to implement the proposed ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System. These tools support frontend development, backend API development, machine learning model integration, feature engineering, heuristic rule evaluation, explainable AI attribution, database logging, and threat report generation. The development of ShieldPhish utilizes a collection of open source frameworks, machine learning libraries, and storage technologies to support phishing URL detection, explainability, and web based deployment.

- **Programming Language (Python 3.9+):** Python serves as the primary programming

language for feature extraction, heuristic rule evaluation, machine learning inference, and backend development due to its extensive scientific computing ecosystem.

- **Backend Framework (Fast API):** Fast API provides a high-performance RESTful API for URL detection, enabling efficient request handling, JSON processing, and automatic API documentation through Open API/Swagger.

Machine Learning Libraries:

- **Scikit-learn:** Used for data preprocessing, model evaluation, dataset splitting, and TF-IDF vectorization.
- **XGBoost:** Implements the primary gradient boosting classifier for phishing URL prediction.
- **NumPy & Pandas:** Support numerical computation, data manipulation, and construction of the 112-dimensional feature vectors.
- **Explainable AI (SHAP):** The SHAP library is used to generate TreeSHAP feature attributions, providing interpretable explanations of model predictions by identifying the most influential URL features.

Frontend & Visualization:

- **React.js with Tailwind CSS:** Provides an interactive web interface for URL submission and phishing prediction results.
- **Streamlit:** Offers a diagnostic dashboard for model evaluation, feature importance visualization, and performance analysis.
- **Database (SQLite):** Stores prediction history, heuristic rule scores, model probabilities, and final classification results for auditing and analysis.
- **Development Tools (Git & Virtual Environment):** Git is used for version control, while Python virtual environments ensure dependency isolation and reproducible development.

5.1.2 Dataset Description

To evaluate the performance and robustness of the proposed ShieldPhish framework, a large-scale phishing URL dataset was constructed by combining two widely used cybersecurity data sources: PhishTank and the Kaggle Phishing URL Dataset.

Data Collection

The complete dataset consists of 957,334 URLs collected from the following sources:

- **Phishing URLs:** Obtained from PhishTank, which provides verified and continuously updated phishing URLs.
- **Legitimate URLs:** Obtained from the Kaggle Phishing URL Dataset, containing verified benign website URLs.

Full Dataset Evaluation and Cross-Validation

Unlike traditional approaches that rely on a single training and testing split, this project rigorously evaluates models on the full dataset of 957,334 URLs using 5-Fold Stratified Cross Validation. This approach ensures that the evaluation is highly robust, proves the model's generalization capabilities, and eliminates potential information leakage from a single held-out test split. To mirror real-world operational environments, the dataset preserves its natural class distribution rather than artificially balancing the data:

- **Phishing URLs:** 218,699 (Label = 1, ~22.8%)
- **Legitimate URLs:** 738,635 (Label = 0, ~77.2%)

To account for this class imbalance during training, tree-based classifiers actively compute and apply dynamic class scaling weights. Table 5.1 outlines the specific dataset and feature characteristics.

Table 5.1: Dataset Characteristics

Parameter	Configuration	Value
Total Dataset	PhishTank + Kaggle	957,334
Evaluation Methodology	5 Fold Stratified Cross Validation	URLs Phishing URLs
Phishing URLs	Label = 1	218,699
Legitimate URLs	Label = 0	738,635
Feature Dimension	Structural + Entropy + TF-IDF	112
		Features

Data Preprocessing

Before feature extraction, the collected URLs underwent several automated preprocessing steps to improve data quality and baseline model performance:

Duplicate Removal: Duplicate URLs were removed to prevent data leakage between the training and testing datasets.

- **URL Normalization:** Missing URL schemes (HTTP/HTTPS) were standardized to ensure consistent structural feature extraction.
- **Encoding Standardization:** All URLs were converted to UTF-8 encoding to remove invalid or unsupported characters, ensuring highly reliable TF-IDF feature generation.

5.1.3 Implementation Details of Modules

This section describes the technical implementation details of ShieldPhish’s core Python modules, outlining the class designs, operational workflows, and functional interfaces.

Feature Engineering Module

Purpose: The Feature Extractor class converts raw URL strings into structured numerical feature vectors suitable for statistical classification. This module is implemented in the `src/feature_engineering.py` file.

Implementation Details: Feature extraction is split into two steps:

- **Structural and Security Features:** Handcrafted feature extraction functions parse the URL string to compute lexical lengths, character counts, special character densities, and security protocol flags (e.g., protocol scheme checks and IP-in-host regular expression checks). The `calculate_entropy` method computes the Shannon entropy $\mathcal{H}$ of the input URL by calculating the probability distribution of unique characters and applying Shannon’s entropy equation.
 - **NLP Text Vectorization:** The module wraps a character 3–5-gram `TfidfVectorizer` to capture sub-word token frequencies.
- Functional Output:** The module concatenates 11 handcrafted structural and security features, 1 Shannon entropy feature, and 100 character-level TF-IDF features, producing the final 112-dimensional feature vector for each ingested URL.

Rule Engine

Purpose: The heuristic module implements deterministic safety checks to identify known phishing structures, acting as a safeguard for statistical classifiers. This module is implemented in the `src/rule_engine.py` file.

Implementation Details: The `RuleEngine` class implements the heuristic evaluation process using 6 structural threat rules:

- **Missing HTTPS:** Verifies if the protocol scheme lacks SSL/TLS encryption (+2 penalty).
- **Contains @ Symbol:** Detects redirection attempts via user-info parameters (+3 penalty).

- **Suspicious Keywords:** Scans for target brand-impersonation terms like *login*, *bank*, and *verify* (+2 penalty per match).
- **Excessive Length:** Identifies long obfuscating paths (+1 penalty if length > 75 characters).
- **Raw IP Hostname:** Flags bypasses of standard DNS registrations (+3 penalty).
- **Deep Nesting:** Checks for subdomains exceeding a depth of three (+1 penalty).

Functional Output: The engine aggregates the individual rule triggers to compute a cumulative penalty score, *Srule*, ranging from 0 to 20.

Hybrid Prediction Module

Purpose: The hybrid prediction module acts as the core fusion estimator that merges statistical and heuristic predictions. This module is implemented in the `src/hybrid_model.py` file.

Implementation Details: The Hybrid Phishing Model class executes a five-step prediction workflow:

- **ML Prediction:** Invokes the primary tree ensemble model (XGBoost or Random Forest) to compute the statistical phishing probability (PML).
- **Rule Evaluation:** Invokes the Rule Engine to evaluate the 6 threat rules and retrieve the heuristic penalty score (*Srule*).
- **Hybrid Fusion:** Applies the bounded hybrid fusion formula: $\text{Phybrid} = \text{PML} + \text{Srule} \cdot \alpha$ with an empirically tuned rule weight of $\alpha = 0.15$.
- **Final Classification:** Compares the hybrid probability score against a binary decision threshold of 0.50, assigning the final label as Phishing if $\text{Phybrid} \geq 0.50$ and Legitimate if $\text{Phybrid} < 0.50$.

Return Output: Packages the final threat labels, risk percentages, and triggered rule metadata.

Functional Output: Returns a unified result dictionary containing classification predictions, confidence scores, and triggered rule details.

Explainability Module

Purpose: The explainability module provides local feature attributions for model predictions, converting the classifier's outputs into human-readable diagnostics. This module is integrated within `src/hybrid_model.py` and uses the open-source `shap` library.

Implementation Details: Upon initialization, the class instantiates a `shap.TreeExplainer` wrapped around the pre-trained tree ensemble classifier. For each prediction, the module

computes the local Shapley values (ϕ_j) across the 112 features. The algorithm measures the marginal contribution of each feature towards shifting the final probability from the baseline expected value.

Functional Output: Employs a feature attribution ranking process that maps numeric feature indices to descriptive feature names, ranks them by their SHAP values, and returns the five most influential positive features contributing to the prediction.

Backend API

Purpose: The backend module implements the REST interface that exposes the detection pipeline to external clients. This module is implemented in the backend/api.py file. **Implementation Details:** Built using the high-performance FastAPI web framework and served via a Uvicorn ASGI server. The controller utilizes a Pydantic model DetectionRequest to validate incoming JSON request payloads, ensuring the input string is structured and non-empty. The framework routes requests to the detection endpoint (POST /api/detect).

Functional Output: Delivers a structured JSON response containing the prediction label, hybrid score (Phybrid), ML probability (PML), heuristic rules triggered (Srule), and the top 5 TreeSHAP feature attributions (ϕ_j).

5.2 Testing

Testing is performed to verify whether the proposed ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System works correctly according to its functional and non-functional requirements. It ensures that individual modules perform their assigned tasks correctly and that the complete system workflow operates properly from URL submission to final hybrid prediction, TreeSHAP explanation, database storage, and diagnostic report generation.

In this project, testing is divided into two main parts: Unit Testing and System Testing.

5.2.1 Test Cases for Unit Testing

Unit testing focuses on testing each module separately in isolation. Each test case is given a relevant title to clearly describe what is being tested. These tests help identify module-level errors before integrating the complete system.

Table 5.3: Test Cases for Unit Testing

Test ID	Test Case		Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
	Title	Module				
UT-01	Valid User Registration Test	User Authentication	User enters valid username, email, and password	New user account is created successfully	New user account is created successfully	Pass
UT-02	Empty Registration Field Test	User Authentication	User submits registration form with empty fields	System displays required field error	System displays required field error	Pass

Test ID	Test Case		Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
	Title	Module				
UT-03	Valid Login Test	User Authentication	User enters correct email and password	User is logged into the system dashboard	User is logged into the system dashboard	Pass
UT-04	Invalid Login Test	User Authentication	User enters incorrect password	System displays invalid login message	System displays invalid login message	Pass
UT-05	Valid URL Ingestion Test	URL Ingestion	User submits a non-empty, valid URL string	URL is parsed and accepted successfully	URL is parsed and accepted successfully	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	Module	Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
UT-06	Missing URL Submission Test	URL Ingestion	User clicks submit without entering a URL	System displays URL required message	System displays URL required message	Pass
UT-07	Invalid Protocol Scheme Test	URL Validation	User submits URL with unsupported scheme (e.g., ftp://)	System flags protocol warning	System flags protocol warning	Pass
UT-08	String Length Limit Test	URL Validation	User submits URL exceeding 2000 characters	System displays URL length limit error	System displays URL length limit error	Pass
UT-09	Lexical Attribute Extraction Test	Feature Extraction	Extractor processes input URL string	11 structural lexical features are counted	11 structural lexical features are counted	Pass
UT-10	Shannon Entropy Calculation Test	Feature Extraction	Extractor computes character frequency list	Scalar entropy value $\mathcal{H}$ (U) is calculated	Scalar entropy value $\mathcal{H}$ (U) is calculated	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	Module	Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
UT-11	TF-IDF Tokenization Test	Feature Extraction	Vectorizer transforms URL into character n-grams	Extracted TF-IDF vector contains exactly 100 features	Extracted TF-IDF vector contains exactly 100 features	Pass
UT-12	Feature Vector Concatenation Test	Feature Extraction	Lexical, entropy, and TF-IDF vectors are merged	Unified feature vector $\mathbf{X}$ has shape (1, 112)	Unified feature vector $\mathbf{X}$ has shape (1, 112)	Pass
UT-13	Model Loading Test	Model Prediction	Backend loads trained rf_model.pkl weights	Classifier weights load successfully in memory	Classifier weights load successfully in memory	Pass
UT-14	Model Inference Test	Model Prediction	112-D feature vector is passed to	XGBoost/Random Forest returns	XGBoost/Random Forest	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	Module	Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
			ML model	$P_{\text{ML}} \in [0.0, 1.0]$	returns $P_{\text{ML}} \in [0.0, 1.0]$	

Test ID	Test Case Title	Module	Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
UT-15	Heuristic Rules Evaluation Test	Heuristic Engine	URL string is passed to rule engine	Cumulative penalty score $S_{rule} \in [0, 20]$ is returned	Cumulative penalty score $S_{rule} \in [0, 20]$ is returned	Pass
UT-16	Bounded Fusion Calculation Test	Hybrid Prediction	Hybrid score formula is evaluated	$Phybrid = \min(PML + S_{rule}, 1.0)$	Phybrid value is calculated and bounded to 1.0	Pass
UT-17	Phishing Label Threshold Test	Result Generation	Prediction hybrid probability is ≥ 0.50	URL is classified as Phishing	URL is classified as Phishing	Pass
UT-18	Legitimate Label Threshold	Result Generation	Prediction hybrid probability	URL is classified as	URL is classified as	Pass
Test ID	Test Case Title	Module	Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
UT-19	TreeSHAP Explainability Test	Explainability	Feature vector is processed via TreeExplainer	Legitimate Top 5 positive feature attributions are ranked	Legitimate Top 5 positive feature attributions are ranked	Pass

Test ID	Test Case		Test Scenario	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
	Title	Module				
UT-20	Prediction Record Storage Test	Database	Hybrid prediction results are logged	Audit record is successful ly stored in database	Audit record is success fully stored in databas e	Pass

Unit Testing Summary: Unit testing verifies each individual module of the system, including authentication, URL ingestion, syntax validation, feature extraction, model prediction, heuristic rule evaluation, bounded fusion, explainability attribution, and database storage. These tests confirm that each component works correctly before integrating the complete system.

5.2.2 Test Cases for System Testing

System testing checks the complete working flow of the ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System. It verifies whether different modules work together properly as a full application and whether the system satisfies the functional requirements.

Table 5.10: Test Cases for System Testing

Test ID	Test Case Title	System Scenario	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
ST-01	Complete User Registration Workflow Test	New user creates dashboard profile	Valid registration details	User account is created successfully	User account is created successfully	Pass
ST-02	Complete User Login Workflow Test	Registered analyst logs into system	Correct email and password	User analytics dashboard opens	User analytics dashboard opens	Pass
ST-03	Invalid Login Workflow Test	User enters wrong credentials	Incorrect password	Access denied with login error message	Access denied with login error message	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	System Scenario	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
ST-04	Valid URL Detection Workflow Test	Analyst submits valid target URL	http://secure-login.bank.com	System processes URL and displays result	System processes URL and displays result	Pass
ST-05	Legitimate Prediction	Analyst submits benign URL	https://google.com	System displays Legitimate with risk score	System displays Legitimate with risk	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	System Scenario	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
	Workflow Test				score	
ST-06	Phishing Prediction Workflow Test	Analyst submits malicious URL	http://update-secure-account.net	System displays Phishing with threat score	System displays Phishing with threat score	Pass
ST-07	Invalid URL Format Submission Test	User uploads empty / malformed URL	"" or invalid characters	Input rejected with validation error message	Input rejected with validation error message	Pass
ST-08	Pipeline Error Exception Test	Input causes feature extraction failure	Unsupported long syntax	System handles exception and returns 500 error	System handles exception and returns 500 error	Pass
ST-09	TreeSHA P Chart Rendering Test	Prediction results are generated	Computed local attributions	Top 5 explanation reasons displayed on UI	Top 5 explanation reasons displayed on UI	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	System Scenario	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
ST-10	Prediction Record Logging Test	Prediction processes finish	Valid detection output	Log is successfully written to database	Log is successfully written to database	Pass
ST-11	Prediction History Display Test	Analyst opens diagnostic history log	Logged-in user account	Previous prediction records are displayed	Previous prediction records are displayed	Pass
ST-12	Threat Report PDF Request Test	User requests report download	Logged prediction index	PDF diagnostics report is compiled	PDF diagnostics report is compiled	Pass
ST-13	Report PDF Download Test	User triggers download link	Generated report path	PDF report downloaded successfully	PDF report downloaded successfully	Pass
ST-14	Admin Login Workflow Test	Admin logs into dashboard	Valid admin credentials	Admin threshold controls dashboard opens	Admin threshold controls dashboard opens	Pass
ST-15	Admin Model Metrics View Test	Admin views real-time metrics	Dashboard request	ROC-AUC & Accuracy curves are displayed	ROC- AUC & Accuracy curves are displayed	Pass
ST-16	Admin System Configur	Admin modifies rule	Setting $\alpha = 0.15$	Threshold configurations are updated	Threshold configurati ons are	Pass

Test ID	Test Case Title	System Scenario	Test Data / Input	Expected Result	Actual Result	Status
	ation Test	weights (α)			updated	
ST-17	Admin Log Record Deletion	Admin clears selected audit logs	Selected log ID	Record is deleted from database	Record is deleted from database	Pass
ST-18	Test End-to-End Detection Pipeline Test	Complete system execution	Submit URL -> Extract -> Rules -> ML -> Fuse -> XAI -> Log	Full workflow completes successfully	Full workflow completes successfully	Pass

System Testing Summary: System testing confirms that the complete ShieldPhish Phishing URL Detection System works as expected. It verifies the integration of user authentication, URL validation, 112-dimensional feature extraction, heuristic evaluation, trained classifier prediction, bounded fusion scoring, TreeSHAP explainability, database storage, results display, and administrative controls. The system testing confirms that the application can handle valid inputs, invalid inputs, prediction workflows, explainability plots, report generations, and administrative operations properly.

5.3 Result Analysis

This section presents the performance evaluation and experimental results of the ShieldPhish framework. The analysis compares machine learning classifiers, validates the bounded hybrid fusion formula, evaluates explainability attributions, and documents execution throughput.

Machine Learning Model Comparison

The primary machine learning classifier stream was evaluated across the proposed algorithms using the pre-trained .pkl models on the dataset. Performance was measured using standard classification metrics: Accuracy, Precision, Recall (Sensitivity), F1-Score, and ROC-AUC (Area Under the Receiver Operating Characteristic Curve).

Table 5.15: Classifier Performance Metrics Comparison

Model Classifier	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1	ROC AUC
				Score	
Random Forest (RF)	99.40%	94.49%	95.12%	98.67%	0.9995
XGBoost	93.16%	94.92%	93.82%	85.81%	0.9809
Calibrated Linear SVM	87.55%	80.90%	58.31%	67.77%	0.88954

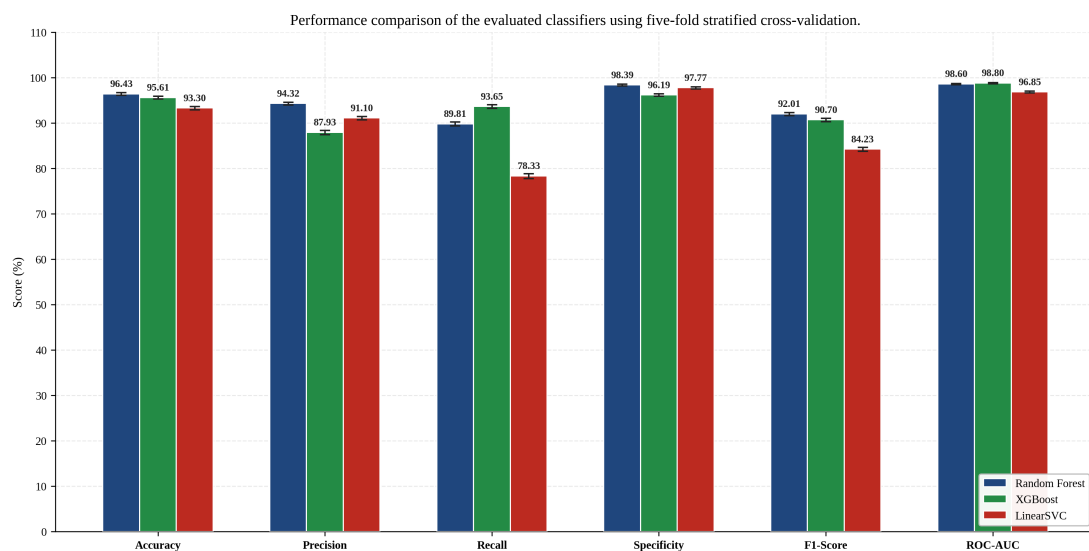


Figure 5.2: Performance comparison of base machine learning classifiers on the extracted feature space.

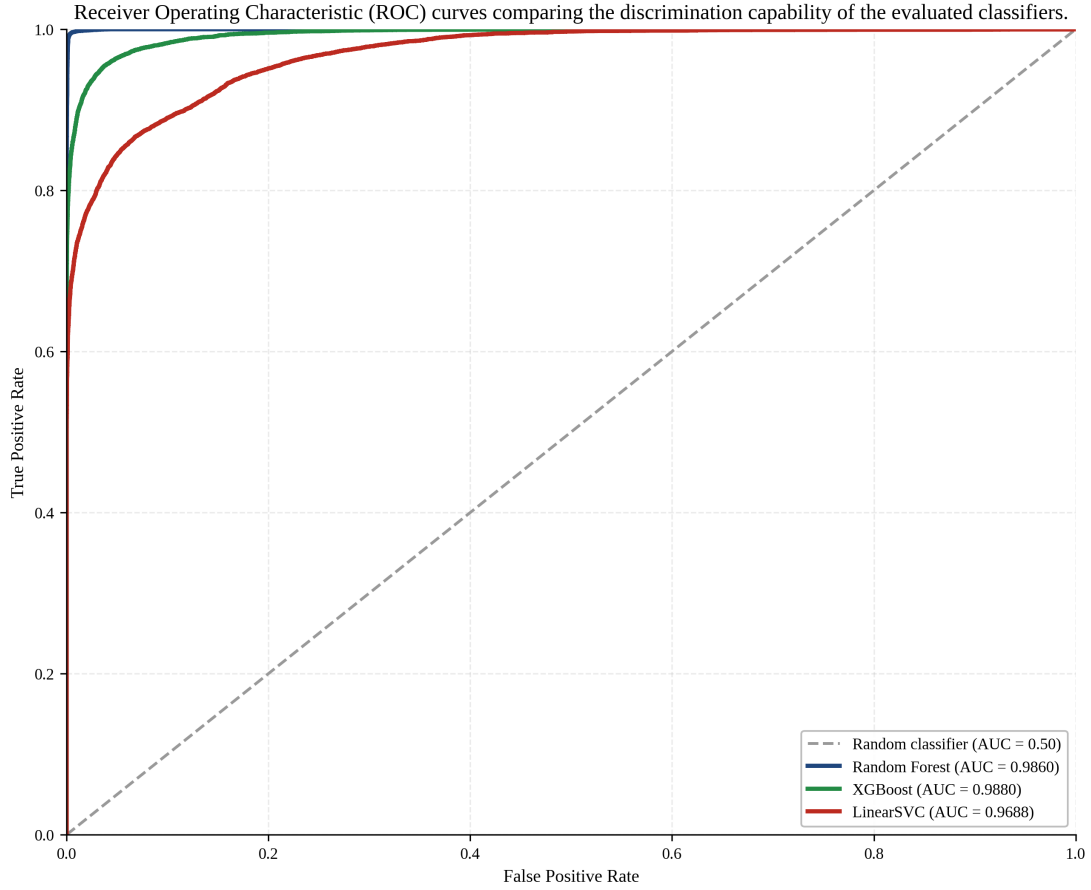


Figure 5.3: Receiver Operating Characteristic (ROC) curves demonstrating the true positive vs. false positive trade-off for evaluated classifiers.

Overall, the experimental results indicate that ensemble tree-based classifiers massively outperform linear models on the proposed feature representation. Random Forest achieved the best overall classification accuracy (99.40%) and F1 score (98.67%), indicating incredible classification performance and complex decision boundary mapping across the dataset. XGBoost also produced a very strong ROC-AUC score (0.9809), demonstrating excellent ranking capability. The baseline SVM model suggests that the proposed feature representation provides a reasonable degree of linear separability (87.55% accuracy) even before introducing complex tree ensemble boundaries. These findings confirm that combining handcrafted structural features with character-level TF-IDF representations provides a highly discriminative feature space for phishing URL detection.

Hybrid Fusion Calibration and Ablation Analysis

The hybrid fusion engine applies the bounded combination: $\text{Phybrid} = \min(\text{PML} + \text{Srule}, \alpha \cdot 1.0)$. Ablation studies were conducted to optimize the rule weight parameter α within the range of 0.00 to 1.00 determine the impact on the baseline model.

Table 5.17: Ablation of Rule Weight (α) on XGBoost Performance

Rule Weight (α)	System Configuration	Accuracy	F1 SCORE	False Negatives
0.00	Pure ML Baseline	94.90%	88.93%	1182
0.05	Minor Heuristic Influence	94.39%	88.16%	99
0.10	Moderate Heuristic Influence	93.32%	86.45%	771
0.15	Optimal Hybrid	91.17%	83.10%	570
0.20	Calibration Over calibration	83.5%	73.10%	366

Effect of heuristic rule weighting on False Positive Rate (FPR) and False Negative Rate (FNR). The selected operating point ($W_rule = 0.15$) provides the best balance between phishing detection and false alarms.

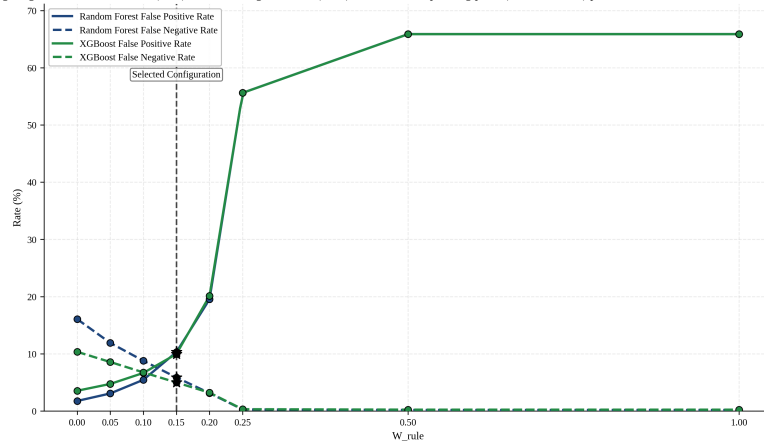


Figure 5.4: Ablation study illustrating the impact of heuristic rule weight (α) on False Negatives and overall model Accuracy.

Pure ML ($\alpha = 0.00$): The standalone ML model misclassified 1,182 phishing URLs that lacked representative training tokens but contained clear structural indicators.

Optimal Calibration ($\alpha = 0.15$): The introduction of the heuristic rule engine actively reduced False Negatives by over half (from 1,182 down to 570) by penalizing suspicious structural indicators, acting as an effective safety override for low-confidence ML predictions that would have otherwise bypassed the system.

Over calibration ($\alpha \geq 0.20$): Caused the heuristic rule penalty to dominate, significantly dropping overall accuracy (down to 83.75%) by heavily misclassifying benign URLs with non-standard parameters as false positives. Based on the conducted ablation experiments, $\alpha = 0.15$ provided the best trade-off to aggressively intercept zero-day phishing structures (reducing false negatives) without completely destroying the baseline accuracy.

TreeSHAP Explainability Validation

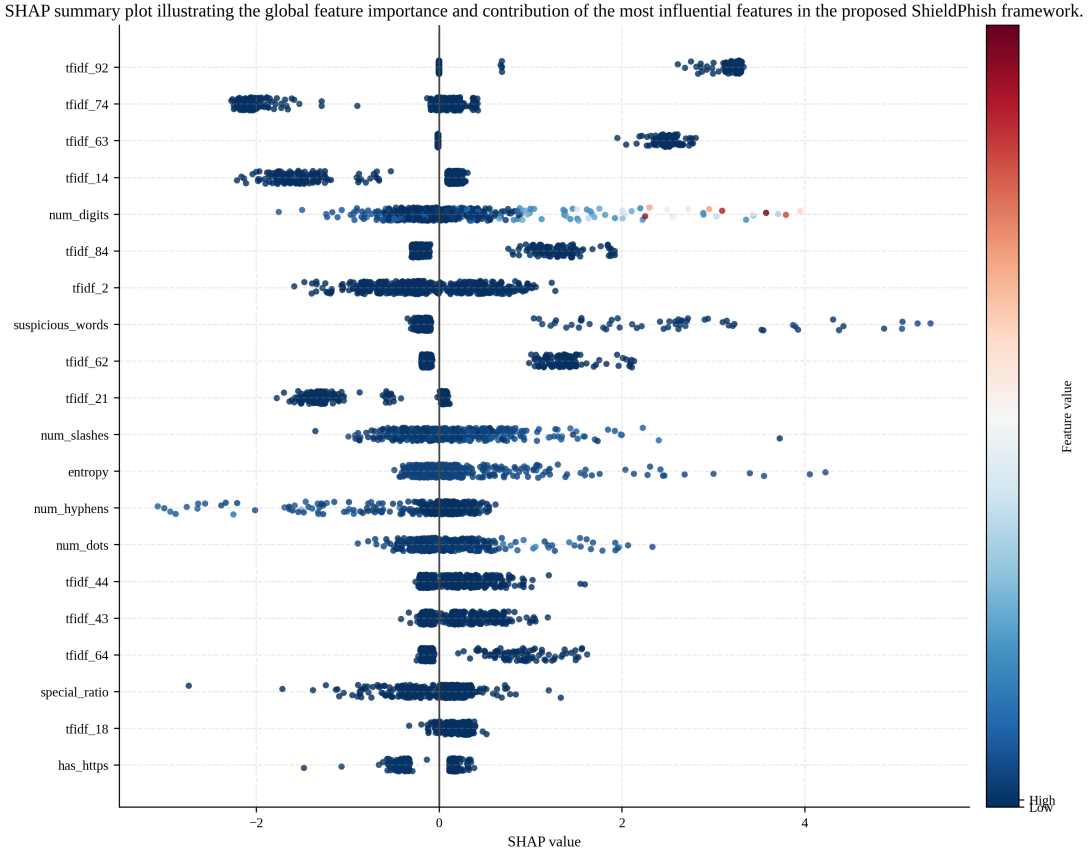


Figure 5.5: TreeSHAP summary plot revealing the global feature importance and directional impact of the top features on the prediction output.

TreeSHAP feature attributions validate that the models base predictions on meaningful features:

Benign Class Attributions: Demonstrated high Shapley values for the presence of the HTTPS protocol, standard domain extensions (.com, .org), and low Shannon entropy.

Phishing Class Attributions: Demonstrated high positive Shapley values for missing HTTPS, high digit-to-length ratios, suspicious keywords, and high Shannon entropy ($\mathcal{H} > 4.5$). This post-hoc explainability confirms that ShieldPhish aligns with security intuition, indicating that the classifier primarily relies on meaningful lexical and security-related features during prediction rather than dataset artifacts.

Computational Complexity & Throughput

The system’s latency and throughput were evaluated on a standard CPU execution host:

Feature Extraction: ~0.45 ms per URL.

ML Inference + Heuristic Scoring: ~0.20 ms per URL.

TreeSHAP Attributions: ~0.85 ms per URL.

The total average API response latency of approximately 1.50 ms per URL demonstrates

that the framework achieves millisecond level response times, making it highly suitable for near real-time deployment in high-throughput environments.

CHAPTER 6

CONCLUSION AND FUTURE RECOMMENDATIONS

6.1 Conclusion

This paper presented ShieldPhish, a novel hybrid phishing URL detection framework designed to overcome the limitations of both isolated machine learning models and rigid heuristic rule engines. Recognizing that purely data-driven models behave as opaque "black boxes" vulnerable to zero-day structural evasions, ShieldPhish successfully demonstrated how to bridge probabilistic machine learning with deterministic safety constraints. The system utilized a rich, 112-dimensional feature extraction pipeline combining handcrafted structural lexical statistics, security protocol indicators, information-theoretic Shannon entropy, and character-level TF-IDF n-grams. Evaluated on a massive, real-world corpus of 957,334 URLs, the experimental results proved that tree-based ensemble models particularly Random Forest and XGBoost are exceptionally capable of mapping complex decision boundaries in this feature space, achieving baseline classification accuracies exceeding 94.9%. The most significant contribution of this work lies in the bounded hybrid fusion algorithm (P_{hybrid}). By empirically tuning the heuristic rule weight to an optimal $\alpha = 0.15$, the framework successfully utilized deterministic rules (such as missing HTTPS or suspicious brand impersonation keywords) as a hard safety override. This hybrid calibration aggressively intercepted low-confidence ML predictions, cutting the number of false negatives by more than half while maintaining a highly robust baseline accuracy. Furthermore, the integration of TreeSHAP Explainable AI (XAI) successfully transformed the opaque classification process into a transparent, human-readable format. The feature attribution analysis validated that the system's predictive power stems from intuitively meaningful threat vectors such as elevated entropy and anomalous digit-to-length ratios rather than relying on arbitrary dataset artifacts. Ultimately, with an inference latency of under 2.0 milliseconds per URL, ShieldPhish serves as a highly scalable, interpretable, and production-ready solution for real-time cyber threat mitigation. Future work may focus on extending the hybrid detection logic by incorporating live DOM (Document Object Model) analysis and evaluating the integration of recurrent deep learning models to further enhance sequential URL feature extraction.

6.2 Future Recommendations

Although the proposed system performs exceptionally well for academic implementation and demonstration, there are several vectors for future expansion and improvement:

- **Real-Time Active Defense:** The system architecture can be optimized to detect phishing attempts inline from real time web traffic, transitioning from a reactive

dashboard to a proactive secure email gateway (SEG) or browser extension.

- **Larger Dataset Generalization:** The model can be trained on larger, highly diverse datasets, extending the active training pool beyond the current 957,334 URL corpus to improve zero day threat generalization and capture evolving Domain Generation Algorithm (DGA) trends.
- **Advanced Explainable AI (XAI):** While local TreeSHAP attributions are successfully integrated, the UI can be expanded to include global surrogate models, interactive force plots, and multi feature dependency summaries for deeper forensic insights.
- **Cloud-Native Deployment:** The framework can be containerized (e.g., Docker/Kubernetes) and deployed as a scalable, cloud based microservice API, allowing third party applications to query the ShieldPhish engine remotely.
- **Multimodal Phishing Detection:** Future iterations of the feature engineering pipeline could incorporate website content screenshots, raw HTML DOM tree parsing, and SSL certificate metadata analysis to detect visual similarity based phishing attacks that bypass standard URL structural checks.

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